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Conspicuous Gas, Cryptic Dust: Spectroscopy and Chromaticity of Complex Periodic Variables

LUKE G. BOUMA,[1,2] COLLABORATORS INCLUDING (PLEASE NOTE: AUTHOR ORDER IS PROVISIONAL!),[1] FACUNDO PÉREZ PAOLINO,[3] LYNNE A. HILLENBRAND,[3] JESSICA J. SPAKE,[2] JULIANA GARCÍA-MEJÍA,[4,5,*] ALLYSON BIERYLA,[5] PATRICK TAMBURO,[5] DAVID CHARBONNEAU,[5] JOHN H. LIVINGSTON,[6,7,8] KEISUKE ISOGAI,[9,10] NORIO NARITA,[11,6,12] AKIHIKO FUKUI,[11,12] ENRIC PALLÉ,[12,13] FELIPE MURGAS,[12,13] ANDREW J. MONSON,[14] ADOLFO S. CARVALHO,[3,5] HOWARD ISAACSON,[15] ANDREW W. HOWARD,[3] DAVID R. CIARDI,[1] LUISA M. REBULL,[1] MOIRA M. JARDINE,[16] JEFF A. VALENTI,[17] AND ALYCIA J. WEINBERGER[18]

[1]*Caltech/IPAC, Pasadena, CA 91125, USA*
[2]*Carnegie Science Observatories, Pasadena, CA 91101, USA*
[3]*Department of Astronomy, Caltech, Pasadena, CA 91125, USA*
[4]*Kavli Institute for Astrophysics and Space Research, MIT, Cambridge, MA 02139, USA*
[5]*Center for Astrophysics | Harvard & Smithsonian, Cambridge, MA 02138, USA*
[6]*Astrobiology Center, 2-21-1 Osawa, Mitaka, Tokyo 181-8588, Japan*
[7]*National Astronomical Observatory of Japan, 2-21-1 Osawa, Mitaka, Tokyo 181-8588, Japan*
[8]*Astronomical Science Program, Graduate University for Advanced Studies, SOKENDAI, 2-21-1 Osawa, Mitaka, Tokyo 181-8588, Japan*
[9]*Okayama Observatory, Kyoto University, 3037-5 Honjo, Kamogatacho, Asakuchi, Okayama 719-0232, Japan*
[10]*Department of Multi-Disciplinary Sciences, Graduate School of Arts and Sciences, The University of Tokyo, 3-8-1 Komaba, Meguro, Tokyo 153-8902, Japan*
[11]*Komaba Institute for Science, The University of Tokyo, 3-8-1 Komaba, Meguro, Tokyo 153-8902, Japan*
[12]*Instituto de Astrofísica de Canarias (IAC), 38205 La Laguna, Tenerife, Spain*
[13]*Departamento de Astrofísica, Universidad de La Laguna (ULL), 38206 La Laguna, Tenerife, Spain*
[14]*Steward Observatory, University of Arizona, 933 N. Cherry Avenue, Tucson, AZ 85721, USA*
[15]*Astronomy Department, University of California, Berkeley, CA 94720, USA*
[16]*School of Physics and Astronomy, University of St Andrews, St Andrews, Scotland KY16 YSS, UK*
[17]*Space Telescope Science Institute, Baltimore, MD 21218, USA*
[18]*Carnegie Science Earth and Planets Laboratory, Washington DC 20015, USA*

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ABSTRACT

Complex periodic variables (CPVs) are young low-mass stars whose light curves show periodic dips indicative of transiting corotating material. The origin and composition of this material are unclear. Here we present new optical and near-infrared spectroscopy and photometry of four CPVs from Magellan, Keck, Hale, MuSCAT1, MuSCAT2, Tierras, KeplerCam, and TESS. Spectroscopically, CPVs show conspicuous evidence for magnetically-bound circumstellar plasma clumps: sinusoidal-in-time Balmer emission out of transit, and Balmer extinction during transit. The link to broadband light curves is nuanced, though, because large night-to-night changes in circumstellar hydrogen emissivity occur without clear changes in light curve morphology. This argues against the sharp flux dips being directly caused by circumstellar plasma, instead implicating dust. Optical chromaticities ($\delta \propto \lambda^{-\beta}$, β=0.79$\pm$0.16) support this, but the power-law breaks in the near infrared: a single power-law under-predicts our observed NIR depths by 2.9σ–5.9σ, depending on statistical treatment. We therefore favor the idea that the CPV light curve dips are caused by dusty plasma clumps with opaque cores and optically thin halos, though we cannot rule out models in which the dust properties vary per-star or per-epoch. Observations at λ>2 μm and λ<0.4 μm would test this interpretation and clarify the dust's origin.

Keywords: Circumstellar matter (241), Stellar magnetic fields (1610), Stellar rotation (1629), Periodic variable stars (1213), Weak-line T Tauri stars (1795)

1. INTRODUCTION

Complex periodic variables (CPVs) present the kind of signal that astronomers usually consider easy: large amplitude, short period, and repeatable. Yet a decade after their discovery, the composition, structure, and origin of the occulting material remain unestablished. These issues are worth re-

Corresponding author: Luke G. Bouma
* 51 Pegasi b Fellow, MIT Pappalardo Physics Fellow

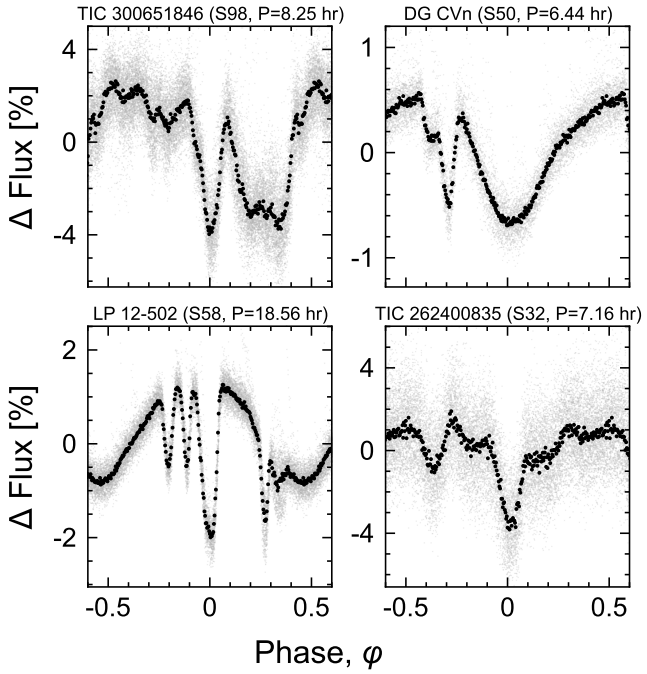


Figure 1. The targets. We acquired new spectra and multi-color photometry for four complex periodic variables: TIC 300651846, DG CVn (TIC 368129164), LP 12-502 (TIC 402980664), and TIC 262400835. Panels show one month of TESS data folded on each object's period, with 120-second cadence flux measurements in gray and their average in black. For DG CVn, we removed a best–fit sinusoid to the P_2=2.60 hr secondary companion's rotation signal (3.1 AU projected separation; J.-L. Beuzit et al. 2004). The time evolution of each target from 2018–2025 is shown in the associated **online movies**: while the periods remain fixed, the morphologies evolve over months to years.

solving. CPVs are young M dwarfs, and the occulting material trapped in their magnetospheres exist at a few stellar radii: the region occupied by the closest planets, and an environment that is otherwise hard to measure. Stars alter planets with both light and particles. While the impact of stellar photons on exoplanets is widely appreciated (K. France et al. 2016; J. E. Owen 2019), the particle environment can be just as influential (D. C. Catling & J. F. Kasting 2017), and means for studying it are scarce (R. O. P. Loyd et al. 2025). A star that traps circumstellar material where we can watch it transit is as close to a space-weather station as nature provides.

Figure 1 shows the main objects of interest in this article; over one hundred analogous systems have been reported by K2 and TESS (L. M. Rebull et al. 2016; J. Stauffer et al. 2017; L. M. Rebull et al. 2018; Z. Zhan et al. 2019; L. M. Rebull et al. 2020; J. Stauffer et al. 2021; E. K. Palumbo et al. 2022; M. Popinchalk et al. 2023; L. G. Bouma et al. 2024). CPVs are identified phenomenologically from their structured, periodic optical light curves; most are M dwarfs with rotation periods shorter than two days, and within current sensitivity limits, none host disks (J. Stauffer et al. 2017; L. G. Bouma et al. 2024). About 3% of stars a few million years old show the behavior, declining to ≈0.3% by ≈110 Myr (L. M. Rebull et al. 2020). The leading interpretation is that clumps of charged circumstellar material corotate with the star (J. Stauffer et al. 2017). The physical requirement is a "centrifugal magnetosphere" (e.g. V. Petit et al. 2013): when the magnetospheric radius exceeds the corotation radius, the effective potential along closed field lines acquires local minima beyond corotation where charged material can accumulate. The accumulation occurs in warped tori for tilted dipoles (R. H. D. Townsend & S. P. Owocki 2005), and more complex surfaces for multipolar fields (J. Krtička et al. 2022).

Spectroscopy offers a direct test of the corotating-material hypothesis, and the necessary data have only recently become available. Early spectroscopic characterization of CPVs was single-shot reconnaissance, and established the class as "weak-lined T Tauri" stars (J. Stauffer et al. 2017) that were chromospherically active with no evidence for accretion. The first time-series spectroscopy of a CPV showed additional sinusoidal-in-time Hα emission at circumstellar velocities, tracing cool ($\lesssim 10^4$ K) plasma clumps at opposing stellar longitudes near 2-4 $R_\star$, consistent with a pinched torus of magnetospherically trapped plasma (L. G. Bouma & M. M. Jardine 2025). Similar Balmer emission variability is known among rapid magnetic rotators across a wide range of masses (J. F. Donati et al. 2000; R. H. D. Townsend et al. 2005; N. J. Dunstone et al. 2006; M. B. Skelly et al. 2008), as is a complementary absorption phenomenology (A. Collier Cameron & R. D. Robinson 1989; A. Collier Cameron & J. A. Woods 1992; T. Q. Cang et al. 2020). Yet those stars do not show complex photometric variability, and before this work, TIC 141146667 was the only unambiguous CPV reported to show both, leaving the question of universality open. Do all CPVs harbor bound plasma? Which of the observed morphological features, such as opposing clumps, night-to-night variability, or Balmer extinction during transits, generalize across the class?

While spectroscopy can reveal the gas, multicolor photometry provides independent evidence for what causes the dips. Ground-based campaigns have established that CPV dips deepen toward the blue, with power-law slopes $\beta \approx 0$–1.5 for $\delta \propto \lambda^{-\beta}$ (M. Onitsuka et al. 2017; Y. Tanimoto et al. 2020; M. N. Günther et al. 2022; C. Koen 2023). This behavior suggests extinction by sub-micron dust. Three issues, however, complicate this interpretation. Dip depths have been derived with heterogeneous detrending choices, which propagate into the inferred chromaticity. The dilution of the observed slope by partially opaque material has been ignored. And the space of considered models has typically been restricted to simple power laws. The one exception was the pioneering study by Y. Tanimoto et al. (2020), who explored broken extinction laws for PTFO 8-8695, albeit interpreting the CPV in that system (L. G. Bouma et al. 2020) as a planet candidate. These limitations matter because the chromaticity is an observable that is directly linked to the question of where the dust in these systems comes from. Are these M dwarfs con-

densing out dust within their own magnetospheres, or trapping the detritus of planet formation? Neither conclusion can be drawn without first establishing what the occulting material does to starlight.

In this work we present time-series spectroscopy and multicolor photometry of four CPVs (Figure 1): 18 nights of ground-based spectroscopy and nine nights of ground-based photometry acquired between 2020 and 2025, usually with simultaneous TESS coverage. High-resolution spectroscopy at sensitivity comparable to the TIC 141146667 observations yields a detection of sinusoidal circumstellar Balmer emission for a second CPV, TIC 300651846, and upper limits for LP 12-502. Lower-resolution spectra with simultaneous photometry show that Balmer extinction during broadband flux dips is ubiquitous, though often with timing offsets. For the chromaticity, we homogeneously analyze our new photometry together with the archival literature, placing 51 dip depths across five stars on a common scale, and we compare four extinction-law models. Under the assumption that a universal extinction law applies across the population, a broken power law between the optical and near-infrared is preferred; absent that assumption, models allowing star-to-star or epoch-to-epoch variability fit as well or better.

Section 2 describes the observations and reductions; Section 3 presents the interpretation of the spectroscopy and the extinction-law fits; Section 4 discusses the structure and possible origins of the occulting material; Section 5 concludes.

2. NEW OBSERVATIONS

2.1. *Selection Function*

We chose CPVs for spectroscopic and photometric follow-up by considering known CPVs in the literature and selecting on the basis of target brightness, period, morphology, accessibility for simultaneous photometry, and binarity (L. M. Rebull et al. 2016; J. Stauffer et al. 2017; L. M. Rebull et al. 2018; Z. Zhan et al. 2019; L. M. Rebull et al. 2020; J. Stauffer et al. 2021; E. K. Palumbo et al. 2022; M. Popinchalk et al. 2023; L. G. Bouma et al. 2024). We weighted these factors as follows.

i) Brightness: Brighter stars provide more photons, enabling higher S/N measurements.

ii) Period: Shorter periods are better, in that they enable covering a larger fraction of a cycle in a single night's observations. Since the morphologies are unpredictable over timescales of more than a few weeks, maximizing the duty cycles maximizes the probability of observing during a sharp, "complex", dip.

iii) Morphology: We selected CPVs that showed sharp dips with large amplitude; such features can be most easily distinguished from spot-induced variability. The desire for sharp dips can be in tension with the desire for short periods, as the shortest period CPVs tend to have smoother features (the origin of the J. Stauffer et al. (2017) "scallop" designation).

iv) Accessibility: We favored targets close to the TESS continuous viewing zones, since they offered a greater number of schedulable windows for simultaneous photometry and spectroscopy.

v) Binarity: We were agnostic to binarity, provided that there was no evidence for close ($<$0.1 AU) binarity that might influence the immediate circumstellar environment of either star. While the CPV binary fraction is similar to that of the field (L. G. Bouma et al. 2024), no CPVs in such close binaries are currently known.

Applying these considerations to the full census yielded five targets for our program: LP 12-502, DG CVn, TIC 300651846, and TIC 262400835 have new data presented in this work; TIC 141146667 was discussed in L. G. Bouma & M. M. Jardine (2025). Table 1 summarizes the stellar properties, while Tables 2 and 3 summarize our spectroscopic and photometric observations. Most of these stars are best-in-class in at least one of the above dimensions: LP 12-502 in morphology, TIC 300651846 in southern accessibility, DG CVn in brightness (due to it being the closest CPV system known, and also a binary), and TIC 141146667 for its short 3.9 hour period and relative brightness.

This work is the first to highlight TIC 262400835 (Gaia DR3 3234917110482839680) as a CPV. Although L. G. Bouma et al. (2024) noted the source, it was omitted from that catalog because automated methods did not recover it; it was instead found in 2020 through the CDIPS project (L. G. Bouma et al. 2019). Its short period and complex morphology motivated two-minute and 20-second cadence observations in DDT028, during which we also acquired MuSCAT1 and MuSCAT2 photometry. Since then, R. M. P. Kerr et al. (2021) reported the system as being part of the $\approx$19 Myr old "Greater Taurus Subgroup 3A", a designation which the latest MocaDB BANYAN-Σ models support (J. Gagné et al. 2026). The system is likely a triple. There is a resolved companion, Gaia DR3 3234920065420339712 (ATO J078.4822+02.6114, TIC 262400836), 10.″6 due West (projected separation $\sim$1,800 AU), with consistent parallax and proper motion. The companion is 0.3 magnitudes bluer in BP-RP, and thus is likely the primary despite having a near-identical G-band magnitude. Our seeing-limited photometry shows that TIC 262400835 is the host of the complex variability; it is likely an unresolved pair on the basis of its Gaia DR3 RUWE (1.5) and photometric excess. The triple interpretation is also consistent with the TESS data, which within a single 20″ pixel show three distinct periods: the large-amplitude complex signal at P_1=7.16 hr; a P_2=4.31 day slow sinusoidal signal; and a faster P_3=12.70 hr sinusoidal signal. As described below, the MuSCAT1 and MuSCAT2 data enable associating the 7.16 hr signal to TIC 262400835 (Gaia DR3 3234917110482839680), which is sufficient for the aims of this article. A. N. Heinze et al. (2018) report the neighbor, TIC 262400836, as a P=4.3 day close binary; we concur with the period but see no evidence for eclipses at that period in the TESS light curves.

Table 1. Overview of Stellar Properties

Star	P (hr)	$T_{\rm eff}$ (K)	$R_\star$ ($R_\odot$)	Age (Myr)	$M_\star$ ($M_\odot$)	$v_{\rm eq}$ (km s^{-1})	$R_{\rm c}$ ($R_\star$)	Multiple?
TIC 300651846	8.25	3159^{+56}_{-84}	$0.61^{+0.04}_{-0.03}$	23	$0.40^{+0.02}_{-0.03}$	89.8 ± 5.2	2.49 ± 0.15	N
LP 12-502	18.56	3090^{+31}_{-59}	$0.37^{+0.02}_{-0.01}$	80	$0.22^{+0.01}_{-0.02}$	24.2 ± 1.0	5.78 ± 0.27	N
DG CVn	6.44	3127^{+51}_{-42}	$0.72^{+0.02}_{-0.03}$	150	$0.40^{+0.02}_{-0.06}$	135.8 ± 4.7	1.79 ± 0.09	Y
TIC 262400835	7.16	3074^{+64}_{-58}	$1.00^{+0.04}_{-0.05}$	19	$0.30^{+0.03}_{-0.04}$	169.6 ± 7.6	1.26 ± 0.07	Y

NOTE—DG CVn is TIC 368129164; LP 12-502 is TIC 402980664. Following L. G. Bouma et al. (2024), effective temperatures and radii are from SED fits and masses are from PARSEC isochrones (Y. Chen et al. 2014). This procedure may yield biased results for binaries unresolved in the underlying photometry (*i.e.*, for the latter two systems). The age for LP 12-502 comes from co-moving pre-main sequence stars in its vicinity (B. M. Tofflemire et al. 2021); ages for the remaining stars are from association memberships (J. Gagné et al. 2026) and have relative uncertainties $\approx \pm 15\%$. The equatorial velocity $v_{\rm eq}=2\pi R_\star/P$ and the Keplerian corotation radius $R_{\rm c}=(GM_\star P^2/4\pi^2)^{1/3}$ are derived quantities. The multiplicity column is Yes/No: DG CVn is a resolved binary (3.1 AU projected separation; J.-L. Beuzit et al. 2004) in which one component is the CPV; TIC 262400835 is likely an unresolved pair within a hierarchical triple (see text).

Table 2. Spectroscopic Observations

Star	Spectrograph	Photometer	Night (UT)	ΔR for Circ. Gas?	Circ. Gas in Emission?	Hα Dips with Flux Dips?	Flare-Induced Spec. Var.?
LP 12-502	DBSP	Tierras	2023 Nov 11	×	×	✓	✓
LP 12-502	DBSP	Tierras	2023 Nov 12	×	×	✓	✓
LP 12-502	DBSP	×	2023 Dec 07	×	×	–	–
LP 12-502	DBSP	TESS	2024 Nov 04	×	×	✓	✓
LP 12-502	DBSP	TESS	2024 Nov 05	×	×	×	✓
LP 12-502	DBSP	TESS	2024 Nov 06	×	×	×	✓
LP 12-502	DBSP	TESS	2024 Nov 07	×	×	✓	✓
LP 12-502	DBSP	TESS	2024 Nov 08	×	×	×	✓
LP 12-502	HIRES	×	2023 Nov 23	✓	×	–	–
LP 12-502	HIRES	TESS	2024 Dec 03	✓	×	✓	✓
LP 12-502	HIRES	TESS	2024 Dec 10	✓	×	×	✓
DG CVn	DBSP	Tierras	2024 Apr 28	?	×	✓	×
TIC 300651846	MIKE	TESS	2025 Jan 02	✓	✓	✓	×
TIC 300651846	MagE	TESS	2025 Jan 18	✓	✓	✓	?
TIC 300651846	MagE	TESS	2025 Jan 19	✓	✓	✓	×
TIC 300651846	MagE	TESS	2025 Jan 20	✓	×	✓	×
TIC 300651846	MagE	TESS	2025 Jan 21	✓	×	✓	×
TIC 141146667†	HIRES	TESS	2024 Feb 17	✓	✓	✓	?

NOTE— The latter four columns indicate (i) whether the spectrograph had sufficient resolution relative to the stellar equatorial velocity to resolve bound circumstellar gas in emission, (ii) whether such gas was seen, (iii) whether the Hα equivalent width time series showed dips synchronous with broadband flux dips, and (iv) whether the spectra and photometry showed synchronous evidence for flare-induced variability. †Data for TIC 141146667 were described in L. G. Bouma & M. M. Jardine (2025).

2.2. *Magellan/MagE*

We observed TIC 300651846 (V=14.1) over four consecutive nights spanning 18 January to 21 January 2025 using the Magellan Echellette (MagE; J. L. Marshall et al. 2008) spectrograph on the Baade 6.5 m Magellan telescope. We used the $1''\times10''$ slit (R≈4,100, δv≈73 km s^{-1}), with a 12 minute cadence, and aligned the slit along the parallactic angle while taking thorium-argon arcs for wavelength calibration once per hour. The seeing averaged $0\farcs8$ over all four nights, rarely exceeding $1''$. We extracted 1-D spectra from the resulting 161 science-ready echellograms using the CarPy data reduction package (D. D. Kelson et al. 2000; D. Kelson 2003), with S/N≈160 per resolution element in the continuum near Hα. We timed these observations to be simultaneous with TESS Sector 88. Adopting the stellar radius and period from L. G. Bouma et al. (2024), TIC 300651846 has $v_{\rm eq}$=89.7 km s^{-1}, implying near-critical sampling of the line core. Figure 2 shows the resulting time-dynamic spectra in the vicinity of $H\alpha$, where the bottom row subtracts the time-averaged spectrum from each night to highlight variability—whether in the line core, or in the circumstellar environment.

2.3. *Magellan/MIKE*

We additionally observed TIC 300651846 on the night of 2 January 2025 using the Magellan Inamori Kyocera Echelle (MIKE; R. Bernstein et al. 2003) spectrograph on the Clay 6.5 m Magellan telescope. We used the $0.7''\times5''$ slit, delivering R≈35,000 (δv≈9 km s^{-1}) in the red arm and R≈28,000 (δv≈11 km s^{-1}) in the blue, and opted to read out unbinned in the spectral direction, and 2× binned in the spatial direction. We bracketed every science observation with a thorium-argon arc, since the main expected advantage of this observation configuration relative to MagE was the velocity resolution, which oversamples the line core. The seeing over the night averaged $0\farcs9$. We extracted 1-D spectra from the resulting 23 science-ready echellograms using CarPy (D. D. Kelson et al. 2000; D. Kelson 2003), yielding S/N≈54 per resolution element in the Hα continuum. These observations were executed simultaneously with TESS Sector 87. Figure 3 shows the resulting time-dynamic spectra.

2.4. *Hale/DBSP*

We used the Double Spectrograph (DBSP; J. B. Oke & J. E. Gunn 1982) on the Palomar 200-inch telescope (Hale/P200) to observe LP 12-502 over seven nights: 11 November to 12 November 2023, 7 December 2023, and 4 November to 8 November 2024. We additionally observed DG CVn (V=12.0), a known unresolved binary (R. A. Osten et al. 2016) in which one component is a CPV, over the night of 28 April 2024. We used the $1\farcs5$ slit, with the 1200 line/mm grating, blazed at 5000 Å on the blue arm, and 1200 line/mm, blazed at 7100 Å on the red arm. This delivered R≈2,200 at Hα, corresponding to δv≈140 km s^{-1}. For LP 12-502, $v_{\rm eq}$=24.2 km s^{-1}, yielding an experiment focused on equivalent width measurement, rather than velocity resolution. For DG CVn ($v_{\rm eq}$=136 km s^{-1}) the velocity sampling near the line core was near-critical. For LP 12-502, we used 10 minute exposures, yielding 442 spectra with 73.7 total hours of open-shutter time, typically with S/N≈200 per resolution element. For DG CVn, we used six minute exposures, yielding 49 spectra over a 4.3 hour baseline. We performed the extraction using `DBSP_DRP` (M. S. Mandigo-Stoba et al. 2022a), which is an extension of the `PypeIt` suite (J. X. Prochaska et al. 2020). We then measured the equivalent widths of the highest S/N Balmer lines—Hα (n=3→2), Hβ (n=4→2), and Hγ (n=5→2)—by numerically integrating the resulting continuum-normalized spectrum using a one-component Gaussian with free amplitude, width, and mean. We estimated the uncertainties on each line width through a Monte Carlo procedure that bootstrapped against the local scatter in the continuum.

The two LP 12-502 nights in November 2023 were conducted simultaneously with the Tierras photometer at FLWO (J. García-Mejía et al. 2020), detailed in Section 2.10 below. The remaining observations, save for 7 December 2023, were conducted simultaneously with TESS. Figure 4 summarizes the results from the most informative nights: 11 November to 12 November 2023, 4 November and 7 November 2024 for LP 12-502, and 28 April 2024 for DG CVn. Figure 5 provides further detail on the Hα, Hβ, and Hγ equivalent widths and line profiles for the November 2023 nights. Data from the remaining nights of 5 November and 6 November 2024 for LP 12-502 are presented in Appendix A—these observations covered orbital phases with no "complex" flux dips; only a single broadband flare on 5 November yielded a corresponding spike in the Balmer lines similar to those visible in Figure 4. The night of 7 December 2023 yielded viable DBSP data, but a TESS perigee contact extended into the DBSP observation, yielding insufficient overlapping photometry for further analysis.

2.5. *Keck/HIRES*

We observed LP 12-502 (V=13.9) over 23 November 2023, 3 December 2024, and 10 December 2024 using the High Resolution Echelle Spectrometer (HIRES; S. S. Vogt et al. 1994) on the 10 m Keck I telescope. We used the C2 decker ($0\farcs86\times14\farcs0$) in the red configuration, yielding a resolution R≈45,000 (δv≈6.7 km s^{-1}). The seeing averaged $1\farcs2$, $1\farcs6$, and $2\farcs1$ in each respective night, with strong winds in the latter two nights. With 15-20 minute cadence, this configuration delivered an S/N of 70-120 per resolution element in the Hα order's continuum, and a total of 20.1 hours of open-shutter time. The star's radius and period from L. G. Bouma et al. (2024) imply an equatorial velocity ($2\pi R_\star/P$) of $v_{\rm eq}$=24.2 km s^{-1}, so the instrument provided a few resolution elements across the line core. We reduced the echellogram using the standard techniques of the California Planet Survey (A. W. Howard et al. 2010).

We acquired simultaneous photometry for the December 2024 nights by observing simultaneously with TESS. We attempted to acquire near-simultaneous Tierras observations for the November 2023 night but had poor weather in Arizona. We detail the results in Appendix A. In short, while

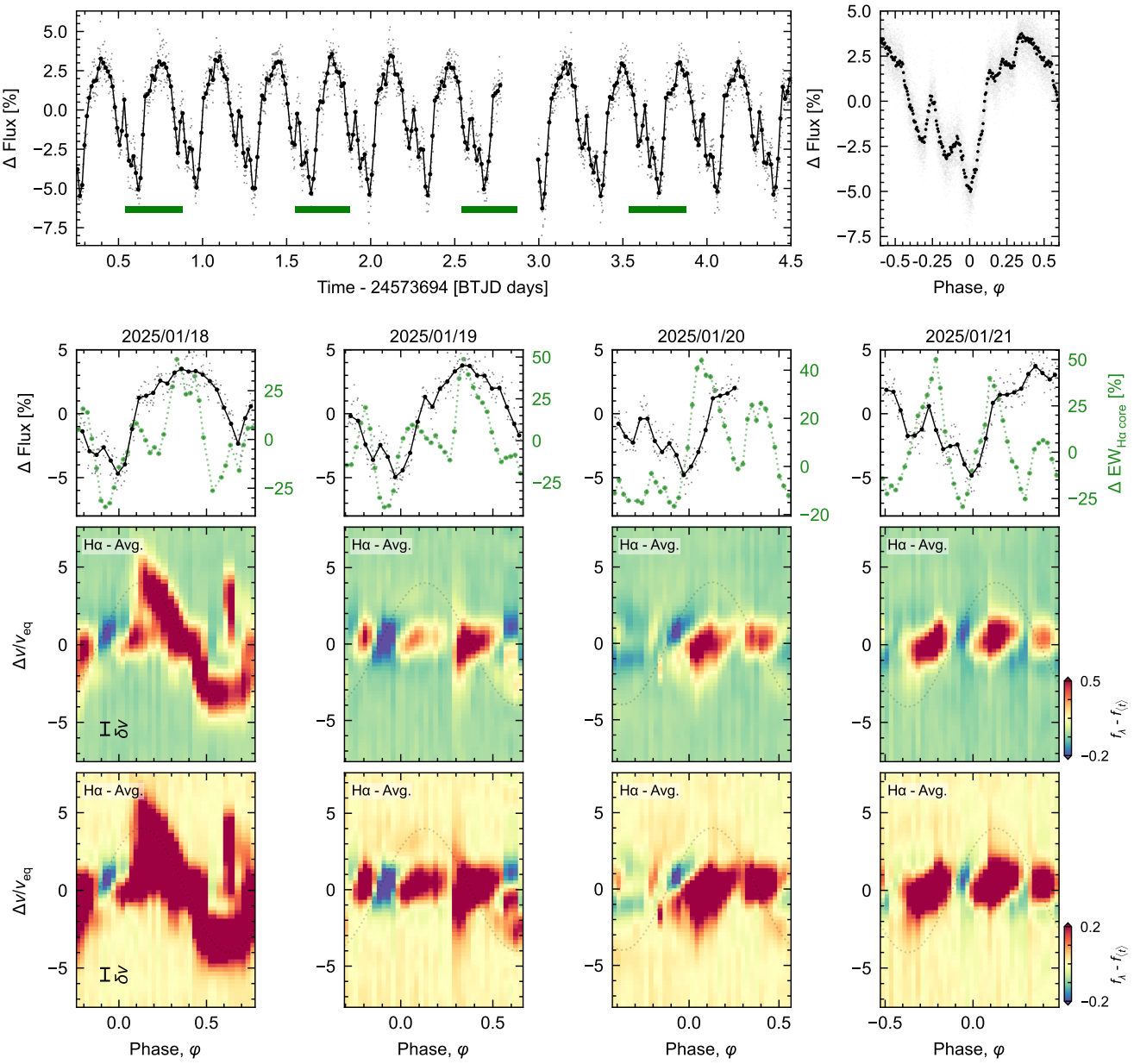


Figure 2. Large changes in circumstellar Balmer emission without any accompanying change in broadband flux morphology. Data are from four successive nights on Magellan/MagE for TIC 300651846 ($P = 8.25$ hr). The top-left panel shows overlapping TESS data (raw data in gray and 20 minute time bins in black); each panel in the next row shows strictly simultaneous flux measurements, with the median-normalized Hα line flux at $|v/v_{\rm eq}| < 1$ in green. The lower two rows show time-series Hα profiles at two different color stretches, with the time-averaged mean profile subtracted. The top-right panel shows the average TESS light curve from 14 January 2025 to 11 February 2025. Large amplitude sinusoidal-in-time Balmer emission is apparent on 18 January 2025. Such emission is weakly present from ϕ=0.3-0.6 on 19 January and 20 January, and not detectable on 21 January. Despite the spectroscopic changes, the complex morphology in the TESS light curves remained stable. The errorbar in the lower left indicates the velocity resolution. The faint model is a sinusoid with K=4 $v_{\rm eq}$ and ϕ_0=-0.12.

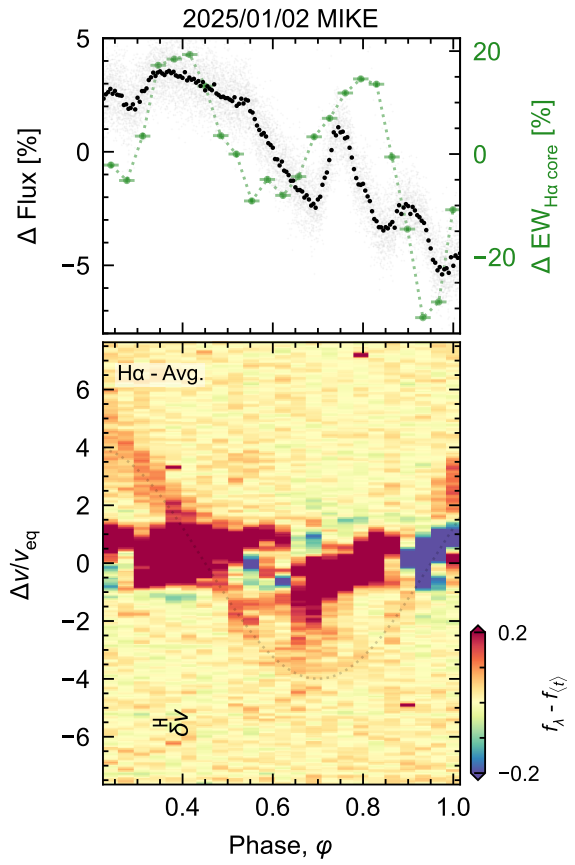


Figure 3. Circumstellar emission for TIC 300651846 on 2 January mirrored 19 and 20 January. The Magellan/MIKE data in this plot have eight times higher resolution than the MagE data in Figure 2; we bin by a factor of two in velocity for clarity, and again phase to $P = 8.25$ hr. Sinusoidal-in-time Hα emits at $\approx$10% of the continuum. Absorption in the line core from ϕ=0.9-1.0 occurs during the transit of the corresponding clump of plasma. The ephemeris is the same as in Figure 2; the average Hα line profile (not shown) is similarly in emission with EW=6.0 $\pm$ 0.3 Å. The faint model is a sinusoid with K=4 v_{eq} and ϕ_0=-0.05, slightly offset from Figure 2.

the HIRES spectra and photometry of LP 12-502 presented abundant evidence for flare-induced variability, we observed only a $\approx$one hour partial transit of a single "complex" dip, which was coincident with excess absorption in Balmer line cores.

2.6. *Hale/TSPEC*

Facundo: To report, or not to report? And what to say? It's a few usable spectra, with little ability to assess time variability. However, they could still be useful for the limit on spot-covering fraction. I could go either way.

2.7. *Magellan/FourStar*

We observed TIC 300651846 ($K = 10.8$) on 11 February 2025 (UT) using FourStar (S. E. Persson et al. 2013), a near-infrared wide-field imager on the Baade 6.5 m Magellan telescope. We used the NB2.09 narrowband filter ($\lambda = 2.082$–$2.118\,\mu$m), in the Double read mode, taking 20.38 s exposures. The broader K-band filter would have saturated the detector given the target's brightness. Young M dwarfs present no prominent emission or absorption lines within the NB2.09 bandpass: the H_2 1–0 S(1) transition at 21,218 Å falls off-band. Variability detected in this filter can therefore be interpreted as continuum variability.

Humidity kept us closed over the first quarter of the night. After opening, we observed continuously for 5.3 hr beginning at $BJD_{TDB} = 2460717.650$, with seeing averaging 0.″9. We reduced the images to light curves using `AstroImageJ` (K. A. Collins et al. 2017) and converted timestamps from JD_{UTC} to BJD_{TDB} using the J. Eastman et al. (2010) barycentric correction code. Figure 6 shows the resulting light curve phased to $t_0 = BJD_{TDB}$ 2460693.244 and $P = 0.34392$ d (8.25 hr), with the simultaneous TESS observation from Sector 88.

2.8. *MuSCAT1 and MuSCAT2*

We observed TIC 262400835 on 13 and 15 December 2020 UT using the MuSCAT2 multi-band imager (N. Narita et al. 2019) mounted on the 1.5 m Telescopio Carlos Sánchez (TCS) at Teide Observatory, Spain. MuSCAT2 is equipped with four CCDs capable of obtaining simultaneous imaging in the g', r', i', and z_s bands with negligible readout overhead. Each CCD consists of 1024×1024 pixels, providing a field of view of $7.4 \times 7.4\,'^2$.

We conducted the MuSCAT2 observations with the telescope in nominal focus. On both nights, we set the exposure times to 60 s for the g', r', and i' bands, and 15 s for the z_s band. We processed the raw data using the MuSCAT2 pipeline (H. Parviainen et al. 2019), which performs standard dark and flat-field calibrations followed by aperture photometry. We also used this pipeline to model instrumental and environmental systematics, specifically accounting for variations induced by airmass changes and pixel-positional shifts due to telescope guiding. We adopted identical reference stars across both MuSCAT2 nights, and adopted an aperture with r=16 px (7.″0) to ensure negligible contamination from TIC 262400836. This aperture choice localized the 7.16 hr "dip" signal to TIC 262400835.

We also observed TIC 262400835 on the night of 16 December 2020 UT using MuSCAT1 (N. Narita et al. 2015), a multi-band imager on the 1.88 m telescope at Okayama Astrophysical Observatory (OAO), Japan. MuSCAT1 is equipped with three CCDs, enabling simultaneous imaging in the g', r', and z_s bands with negligible readout overhead. Each CCD provides a field of view of 6.1×6.1 arcmin^2 over 1024×1024 pixels.

We used exposure times of 60 seconds in the g', r', and z_s bands. We dark-subtracted and flat-fielded the raw images, and performed aperture photometry following A. Fukui et al. (2011), adopting an aperture radius of 8, 10, and 14 px (2.″9, 3.″6, and 5.″1) to exclude the flux of the companion $\sim$10″ to the West. These observations were conducted simultane-

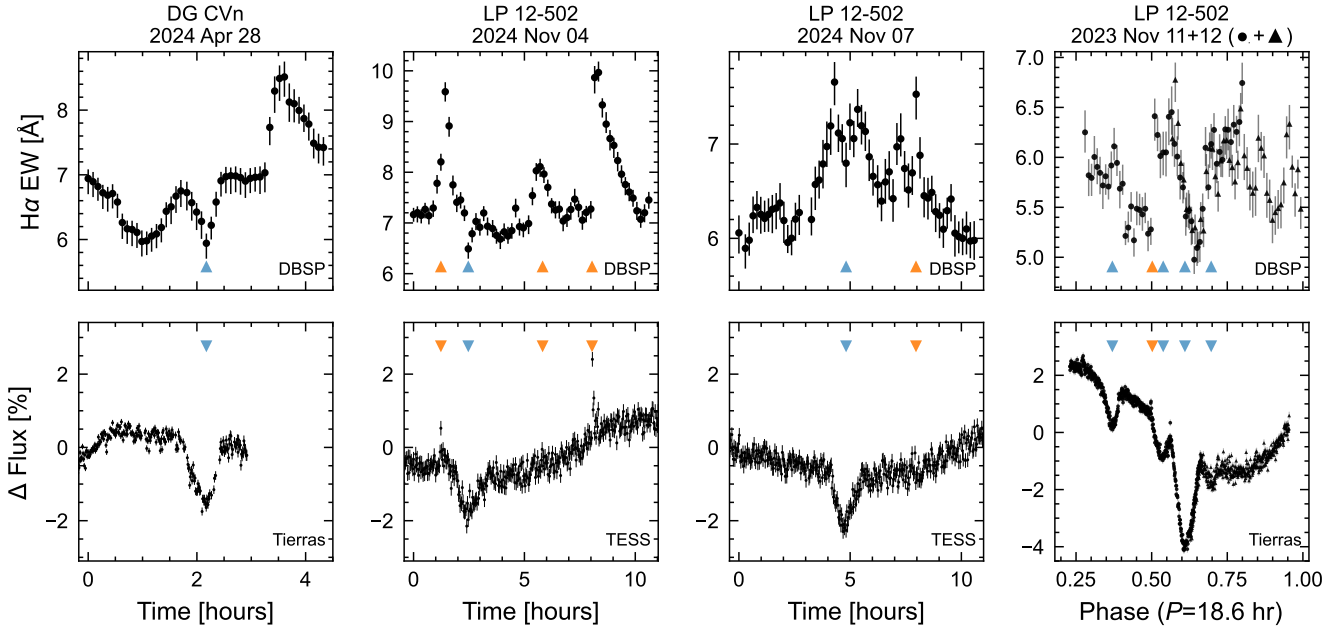


Figure 4. CPVs show Balmer line extinction during broadband transits—however, Balmer variability is dominated by flares. Panels show Hale/DBSP (R≈2,200) Hα equivalent widths (EWs) vs. simultaneous Tierras and TESS photometry. Minute-timescale optical flares (orange arrows) are associated with hour-timescale Balmer EW flares. The ∼hour timescale optical dips that define the CPV class (blue arrows) tend to be contemporaneous with Balmer EW dips, consistent with transiting clumps of dusty plasma (see discussion in Section 4.1). The rightmost column is shown as a function of phase since the data were acquired two orbital cycles apart.

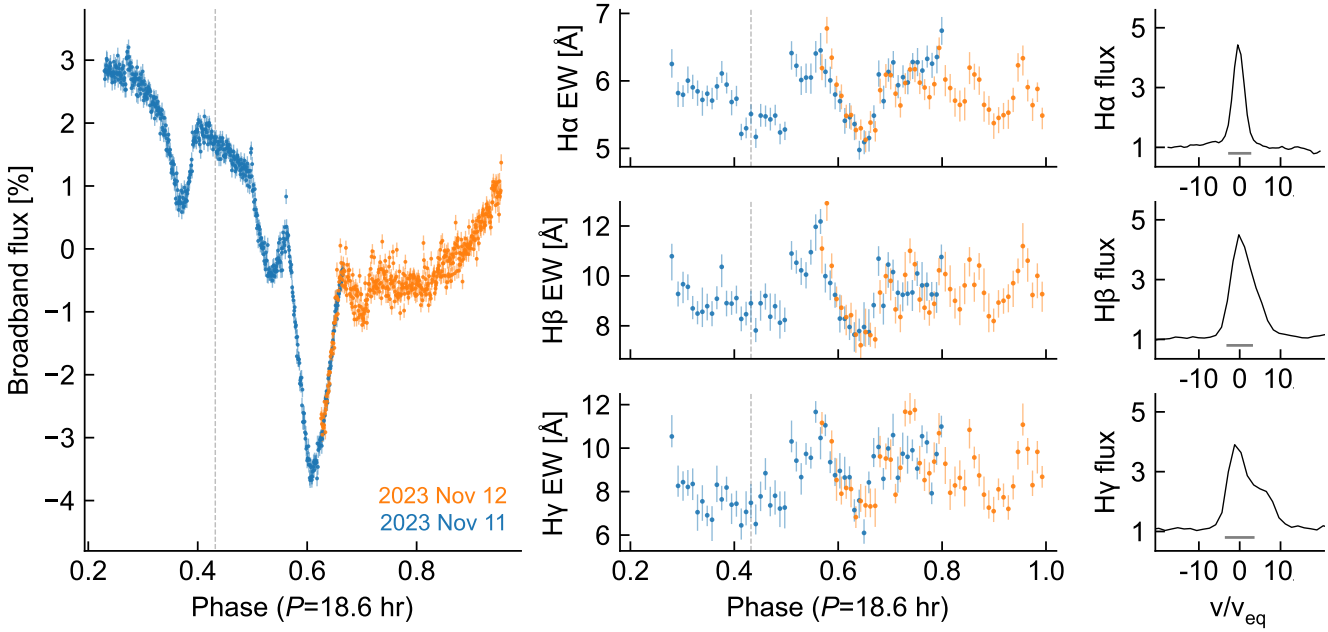


Figure 5. Detail of Figure 4, showing Hα, Hβ, and Hγ equivalent widths and line profiles for LP 12-502 on 11 and 12 November, 2023. The **online movie** shows the line profiles for each exposure, switching from Nov 11 to Nov 12 near ϕ≈0.8. The target, LP 12-502, has v_{eq}=24.2 km/s; gray horizontal lines denote a single velocity resolution element ($\delta v \approx c/R$). The Balmer line equivalent widths vary at the 5-50% level, coincident in time with 1-2% variability in the broadband Tierras filter. There is strong evidence for line shape differences between Hα, Hβ, and Hγ, and weak evidence for time variability in the velocity-resolved emission profile of Hγ. The jump at ϕ≈0.50 was likely flare-induced, based on similar timing coincidences in Figure 4.

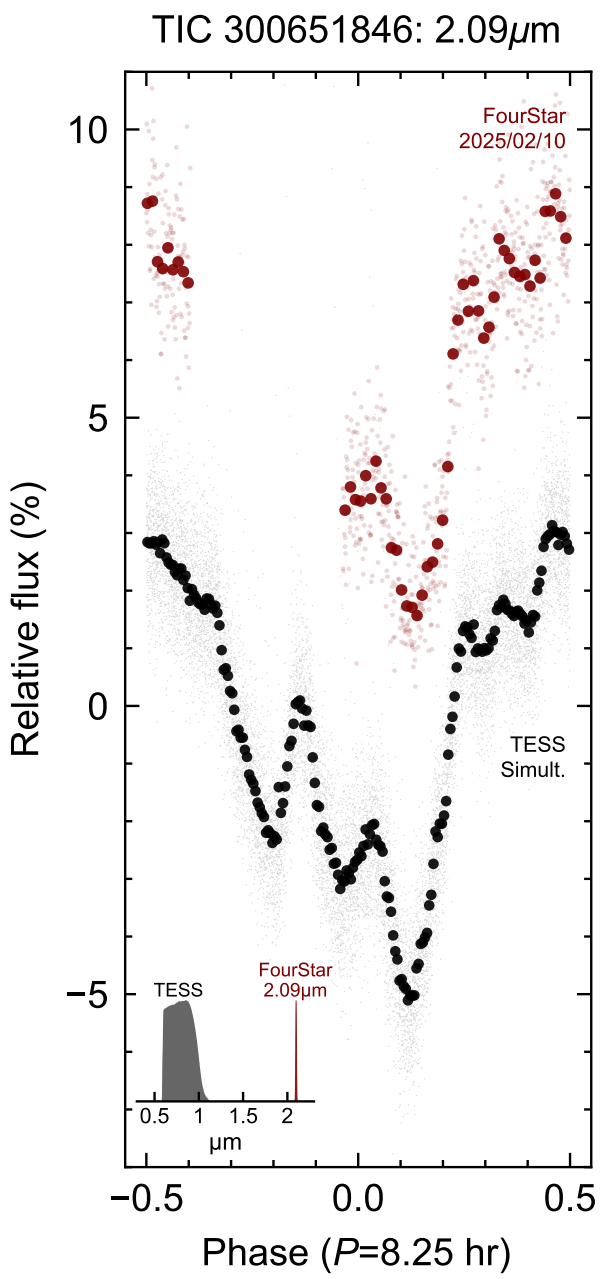


Figure 6. Magellan/FourStar 2.09 μm vs. simultaneous TESS (0.6-1 μm) observations. The target, TIC 300651846, has a period of 8.25 hours and was observable for two-thirds of a rotation cycle with FourStar on 11 February 2025. Simultaneous TESS data from Sector 88 are plotted underneath. The two bands (filter profiles in lower left) show dip depths in a ratio of 0.80±0.03 (NB2.09/TESS).

ously with TESS Sector 32, and the resulting light curves are shown in Figure 7 alongside the MuSCAT2 data.

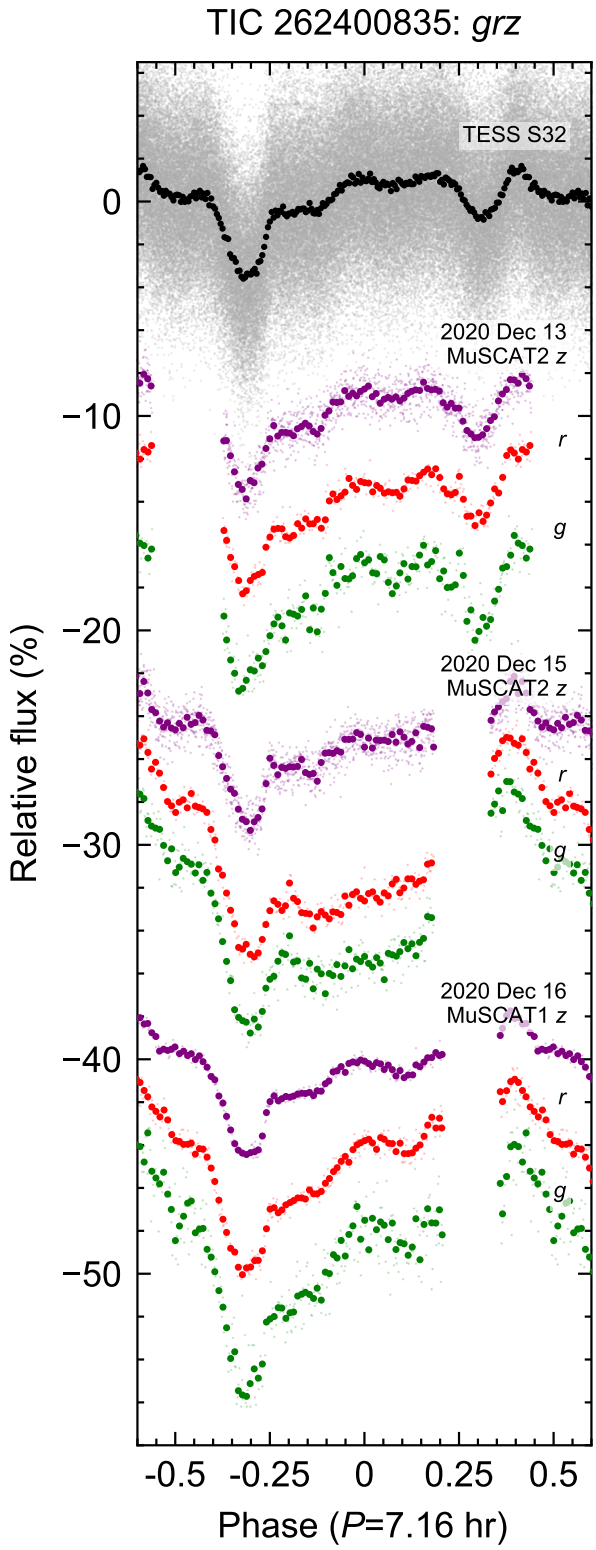


Figure 7. MuSCAT1 and MuSCAT2 $g'r'z_s$ vs. simultaneous TESS observations. The target, TIC 262400835, has a period of 7.16 hours. The plotted TESS data, acquired at 20 second cadence, span 19 November 2020 to 17 December 2020.

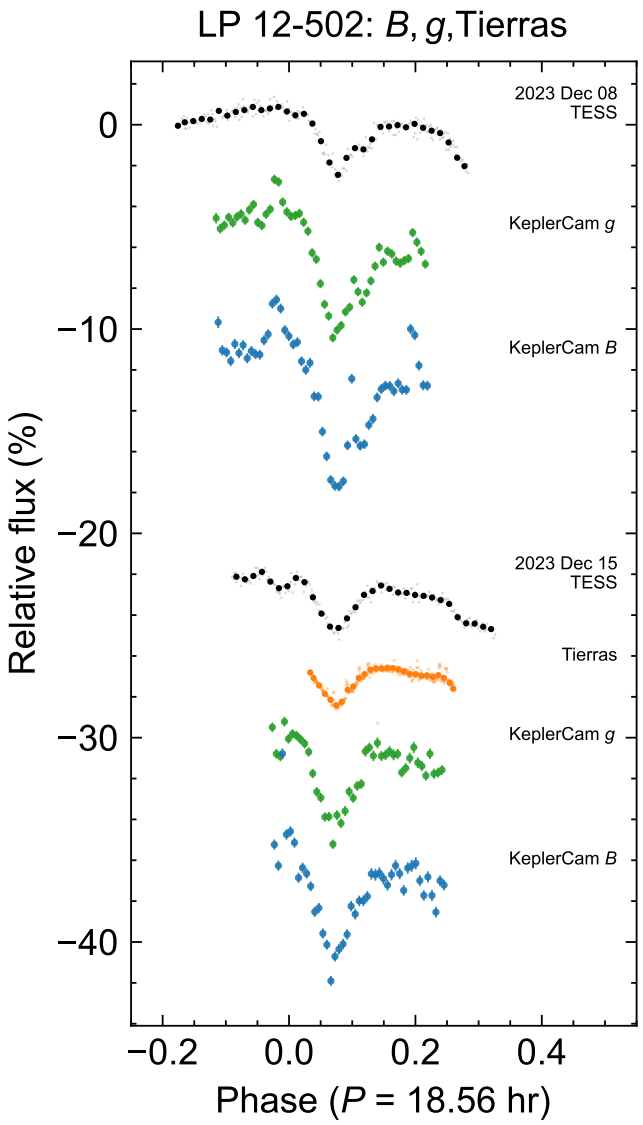


Figure 8. KeplerCam gB and Tierras vs. simultaneous TESS observations. The target, LP 12-502, has a period of 18.56 hours. The plotted TESS data are excerpts of 120 second cadence data from Sector 73.

2.9. *KeplerCam*

We observed LP 12-502 on 8 and 15 December 2023 UT using the KeplerCam CCD on the 1.2 m telescope at the Fred Lawrence Whipple Observatory (FLWO) at Mount Hopkins, Arizona. We took observations in alternating g' and B filters with 60 sec exposure in g' and 300 sec in B. KeplerCam is a 4096×4096 Fairchild CCD which has a field-of-view of $23.'1 \times 23.'1$ and an image scale of 0.672"/pix when binned by 2. We reduce the data using standard IDL routines, and performed aperture photometry using AstroImageJ (K. A. Collins et al. 2017). The resulting measurements are in Figure 8.

2.10. *Tierras*

We observed LP 12-502 and DG CVn with the Tierras Observatory, a refurbished 1.3 m ultra-precise fully-automated photometer located at the F. L. Whipple Observatory atop Mount Hopkins, Arizona (J. García-Mejía et al. 2020). The facility carries out all observations through a single custom narrow bandpass filter (λ_C = 863.5 nm, FWHM = 40 nm) that minimizes precipitable water vapor (PWV) errors known to limit photometric precision from the ground (e.g., C. W. Stubbs et al. 2007; C. H. Blake et al. 2008; Z. K. Berta et al. 2012). Tierras is also equipped with a deep-depletion 4K × 4K e2v CCD (15 μm pixels) with a plate scale of $0.''43$ pixel^{-1} operated in frame-transfer (shutter-less) mode, yielding a field of view (FOV) of $15' \times 29'$.

We observed LP 12-502 during the UT nights of 11 November, 12 November, and 15 December 2023, as well as DG CVn on the UT night of 28 April 2024. The telescope was in focus throughout. We exposed for 45 s on LP 12-502, collecting 556, 421, and 296 frames over 8.1, 6.1, and 4.2 hr, respectively, and for 30 s on DG CVn, collecting 731 frames over 7.9 hr. Our LP 12-502 observations sampled airmasses between 1.52 and 1.74, a consequence of the target's high declination ($+80.^\circ5$), which renders it circumpolar from Mount Hopkins, while our DG CVn observations sampled airmasses between 1.00 and 1.80. Skies were clear on all four nights, with relative humidities between 10% and 52%. The median image FWHM was $0.''9$, $1.''7$, $1.''3$, and $1.''1$, listed chronologically.

We produced light curves from the Tierras images using the facility's pipeline, which we briefly summarize here. The pipeline first bias-corrects the images by subtracting bias levels derived from the overscan region of each detector half, each of which is read through a separate amplifier, and it subsequently stitches the two halves together. We did not flat-field the data given that, when these observations were gathered, light entering the Tierras optical path off-axis produced an additive glow that a flat field would not have corrected. This effect has since been suppressed with additional internal baffling. We then computed an astrometric solution for each frame, and extracted photometry for stars brighter than $G_{\rm RP}$ = 17 mag. We measured fluxes through a family of circular apertures spanning 5 to 20 pixels in radius, and estimated the local sky in each case from an annulus running from 35 to 55 pixels, taking the 2σ-clipped median of the pixels it encloses. Our per-frame error budget combined photon noise from the star and from the sky with dark current, read noise, and scintillation (G. Stefansson et al. 2017). We discarded frames in which the target flux encroached on the detector's non-linear regime, which is why only 609 of the 731 DG CVn frames were kept for the subsequent analysis. We retained all 1273 LP 12-502 frames.

Finally, we normalized our target fluxes by a weighted sum over the ensemble of comparison stars, with the weights set by the iterative scheme detailed in P. Tamburo et al. (2022). In this scheme, stars that contribute noise are progressively downweighted until the weights stop changing. We then

Table 3. Multicolor Photometric Observations

Star	Instrument	Night (UT)	Bandpasses	Dips Seen?	Chromatic?
TIC 262400835	MuSCAT2	2020 Dec 13	g, r, i, z, TESS	✓	?
TIC 262400835	MuSCAT2	2020 Dec 15	g, r, i, z, TESS	✓	✓
TIC 262400835	MuSCAT1	2020 Dec 16	g, r, z, TESS	✓	✓
LP 12-502	KeplerCam	2023 Dec 08	B, g	✓	✓
LP 12-502	KeplerCam + Tierras	2023 Dec 15	B, g, Tierras	✓	✓
LP 12-502	KeplerCam	2023 Dec 16	B, g	✓	?
TIC 300651846	FourStar + TESS	2025 Feb 11	NB2.09, TESS	✓	?

NOTE—"Dips Seen?" indicates whether sharp flux dips were observed; "Chromatic?" indicates whether the dip depths differed significantly between bandpasses. The FourStar entry is the central near-infrared constraint of this work.

freeze the converged weights and reuse them for every night of a given target. Holding the ensemble fixed in this way guarantees that a brightness change measured for a variable target between two nights cannot be an artifact of shifts in the comparison set. For each target we kept the aperture that minimized the measured scatter: 17 pixels (7.″3) for LP 12-502, with an ensemble of 403 comparison stars, and 10 pixels (4.″3) for the brighter DG CVn, with 86 comparison stars. Individual exposures for the two targets reach a photometric precision of 1.1 to 1.7 ppt.

2.11. *Dip Depth Measurement*

We measured the depth, mid-time, and duration of each dimming event in the ground-based photometry by treating every observed dip independently. We fitted the light curves using a two-stage least squares routine. We first manually provided a guess for which points were "in-dip", which neighboring points provided the "out-of-dip" baseline, and which points to exclude due to flaring. We constrained this initial guess to be identical across bandpasses. We then fit a smooth rotational baseline, $b(t)$, to only the out-of-dip points, and subsequently fit the residual, $f(t)-b(t)$, with a dip model. We explored various models for the rotational baseline (low-order polynomial; low-order Fourier series) and the dip model (hyperbolic secant per L. Yu et al. 2015; trapezoidal dip), always requiring the dip epoch and total duration to be identical over bandpasses, but letting the depth and shape parameters vary. We assessed the goodness of fit for each model using the reduced χ^2, as initially evaluated by setting the flux uncertainties to the point-to-point out-of-dip RMS (the 84$^{\rm th}$-16$^{\rm th}$ percentile spread of the first differences $\Delta F_j = F_j - F_{j+1}$), and subsequently renormalized to force the best-fitting model to have $\chi^2_{\rm red} \equiv 1$. We then compared the model evidence using the Bayesian Information Criterion (BIC). We found across all the photometric datasets that at most second-order baseline models minimized the BIC, and that the trapezoidal dip model (parametrized by depth, duration, mid-time, and fractional ingress/egress duration) offered better $\chi^2_{\rm red}$ and ΔBIC than the hyperbolic secant (parametrized by depth, width, and mid-time). Table 4 lists the resulting depth measurements, based on the trapezoidal model and the BIC-preferred out-of-dip baseline models. Appendix B shows the resulting fits with each photometric dataset.

3. INTERPRETATION

3.1. *Bound circumstellar gas in emission*

The 18 January 2025 Magellan/MagE observations of TIC 300651846 (Figure 2) show sinusoidal time-varying Hα emission with semi-amplitude $K \approx 4\,v_{\rm eq}$. To our best knowledge, the only available explanation is emission from a cool ($\lesssim 10^4$ K) plasma clump trapped in corotation. This is the second CPV showing this phenomenology, after TIC 141146667 (L. G. Bouma & M. M. Jardine 2025). TIC 141146667 showed two clumps at opposite stellar longitudes, which is an azimuthal distribution predicted by models of rigidly rotating magnetospheres with tilted dipolar magnetic fields (R. H. D. Townsend 2008). Such models tend to produce "pinched" plasma tori[1]. For TIC 300651846, the clearest signal shows a single clump appearing at ϕ=0.1 near $\approx 4\,R_\star$, and rotating with the star for the next six hours. The clump emits with an EW $\approx$60% that of the star, and is internally unresolved at MagE's resolving power ($\approx$73 km s^{-1}). A secondary feature in the 18 January 2025 night appears from ϕ=0.6-0.7. While this feature's interpretation is complicated by its brief lifetime, the star is presenting a triple-lined Hα profile in three separate exposures. This is consistent with the idea of opposing plasma clumps becoming visible at phase quadrature, when they are maximally visible.

We estimate the number density of the longer-lived plasma clump based on the emitting line's luminosity as follows. For the star, we observe a time-averaged Hα equivalent width

[1] See http://user.astro.wisc.edu/~townsend/static.php?ref=rrm-movies#Download_Bundles last accessed 8 July 2026.

Table 4. Dip depths by bandpass

Star	Date (UT)	Band	δ (%)	Ref.
TIC 262400835	2020 Dec 13	g	3.36 ± 0.19	1
		r	2.54 ± 0.10	1
		i	2.74 ± 0.07	1
		z	2.69 ± 0.09	1
		TESS‡	0.96 ± 0.12	1
	2020 Dec 15	g	4.67 ± 0.15	1
		r	3.46 ± 0.10	1
		i	3.64 ± 0.08	1
		z	2.99 ± 0.09	1
		TESS‡	1.95 ± 0.23	1
	2020 Dec 16	g'	4.30 ± 0.20	1
		r'	3.52 ± 0.08	1
		z_s	2.96 ± 0.06	1
		TESS‡	2.17 ± 0.38	1
LP 12-502	2023 Dec 08	B	5.57 ± 0.28	1
		g	4.63 ± 0.18	1
		TESS	2.44 ± 0.08	1
	2023 Dec 15	B	4.48 ± 0.44	1
		g	3.48 ± 0.24	1
		Tierras	2.75 ± 0.09	1
		TESS	2.18 ± 0.24	1
TIC 300651846	2025 Feb 11	TESS	4.07 ± 0.05	1
	(dip 1)	NB2.09	3.27 ± 0.10	1
	(+1.4 h)	TESS	0.62 ± 0.08	1
		NB2.09	1.06 ± 0.20	1
	(+2.1 h)	TESS	0.80 ± 0.05	1
		NB2.09	0.81 ± 0.10	1
TIC 435899024	2021 May 25–	B	12.47 ± 0.40	2†
	–2021 June 01	V	11.96 ± 0.41	2†
		R	10.79 ± 0.29	2†
		I	9.11 ± 0.21	2†
PTFO 8-8695	2014 Jan 19	I+z	2.18 ± 0.08	3†
		H	1.38 ± 0.05	3†
	2016 Feb 9	g'	2.57 ± 0.34	4†
		r'	1.69 ± 0.12	4†
		z_s	0.99 ± 0.10	4†
	2014 Feb 23	I_C	2.59 ± 0.10	5†
		K_s	1.07 ± 0.20	5†
	2014 Dec 27	I_C	1.25 ± 0.08	5†
		K_s	0.97 ± 0.11	5†
	2015 Jan 10	I_C	1.34 ± 0.13	5†
		K_s	1.24 ± 0.22	5†
	2015 Jan 23	I_C	1.56 ± 0.14	5†
		J	1.00 ± 0.22	5†
	2015 Feb 10	I_C	1.64 ± 0.15	5†
		H	0.87 ± 0.11	5†
	2015 Feb 14	I_C	2.16 ± 0.05	5†
		K_s	1.10 ± 0.10	5†
	2015 Feb 23	I_C	1.44 ± 0.17	5†
		K_s	1.12 ± 0.27	5†
	2016 Nov 25	I_C	1.01 ± 0.12	5†
		J	1.09 ± 0.11	5†
	2016 Dec 9	I_C	1.38 ± 0.15	5†
		J	0.90 ± 0.10	5†

NOTE—†Denotes literature photometry refitted in this work. ‡Listed for completeness but excluded from the extinction-law fits due to low S/N and an uncertain crowding correction (Section 3.3.1). *References*: (1) This work. (2) C. Koen (2023) SAAO 1m/CCD "J1252"; (3) L. Yu et al. (2015) Baade 6.5m/FourStar H and TRAPPIST I+z; (4) M. Onitsuka et al. (2017) OAO 1.88 m/MuSCAT simultaneous; (5) Y. Tanimoto et al. (2020) HHO 1.5 m/HONIR.

of 6.0 ± 0.3 Å. Given the SED-derived $L_\star$=0.033±0.006 $L_\odot$ (L. G. Bouma et al. 2024), this implies that the stellar Hα line radiates $\approx 3.0 \times 10^{28}$ erg s^{-1}. From the same SED fit, the star has $R_\star$=0.61±0.04 $R_\odot$. Following Appendix C of L. G. Bouma & M. M. Jardine (2025) and approximating all the emission as coming from case B radiative recombination, a homogeneous sphere of radius $r \approx 0.1\,R_\star$ would yield $n_H \approx 8 \times 10^{11}$ cm^{-3}, with a total clump mass $M_{gas} \approx 5 \times 10^{17}$ g—all on the night of 18 January 2025.

The other nights in January 2025 showed much weaker circumstellar emission. Close inspection of the 19 January and 20 January MagE data (Figure 2) shows an emissive component appearing at similar orbital phases as on 18 January. The MIKE data from 2 January show a similar signal (Figure 3). However this emission has an equivalent width ≈10% that of the star's average Hα profile, rather than ≈60%; on 21 January, no emission is not detectable. Under radiative recombination, $n_H \propto L_{H\alpha}^{1/2}$, and so this six-fold decrease in luminosity corresponds to a number density decrease of 2.5×. Despite this change in the circumstellar plasma number density, the simultaneous light curve morphology in Figure 2 appears unchanged.

The implication is that, at least over these five nights of observations, the light curve morphology was not directly tied to the circumstellar plasma number density. This is consistent with previous discussion (e.g. Section 5.6 of L. G. Bouma et al. 2024) arguing that there is no microphysical mechanism by which gas can provide the opacity needed to explain both the observed transit depths and their chromaticities. The spectra show that gas clumps are present—but dust remains the sole viable opacity source. The gas and dust broadly trace each other, in that Balmer extinction accompanies the broadband dips (Section 3.2). However, the large swings in gas emissivity without any change in dip morphology indicate that the dust column is not simply proportional to the gas density.

3.2. *Balmer extinction during transits*

In cases where the star's equatorial velocity is much greater than the spectrograph's resolution, it is not possible to resolve circumstellar emission from the star's chromosphere as in Figure 2. Nonetheless, during a plasma clump's transit, one would expect the plasma to scatter or absorb stellar Hα photons such that the Hα transit mirrors the broadband flux. We refer to this combination of absorption and scattering as extinction. Figures 4 and 5 show low-resolution data that appear consistent with the hypothesis of greater Hα extinction during broadband transits: the local minima in flux tend to be correlated with local minima in the Hα equivalent width time-series. Moreover, Figures 2 and 3 all show similar absorption in the Hα line cores of TIC 300651846 from ϕ=0.9–1.0, consistent with absorption or scattering from the same plasma clump that is then seen in emission at phase quadrature.

However, there are two nuances in interpreting this type of low resolution data. First, the largest amplitude variability in Hα comes not from transiting plasma clumps, but from

flares: minute-timescale broadband optical flares correspond to hour-long Balmer variability. The orange markers in Figure 4 and in Appendix A.2 highlight such flare-induced variability, which complicates interpretation of Hα EW time-series data. The second nuance is connected to the *consistency* with which local minima in flux yield local minima in Hα EW. The broadband flux dips in the three leftmost columns of Figure 4 are all coincident in time with local minima in their corresponding Hα EW time-series. However, the nights of 11 and 12 November 2023 showed four local minima in flux. The largest of these local flux minima, which was observed on both nights at $\phi\approx0.62$, corresponds to an Hα minimum that *lagged* the flux minimum on both nights by $\approx$50 minutes. The green "Hα core" lines in Figures 2 and 3 show an analogous offset with the opposite sign: for TIC 300651846, the deepest Hα minimum *led* the deepest broadband flux minimum by $\approx$25 minutes on all five nights in January 2025. The origin of these time offsets is not clear, but their repeatability suggests that they are a stable feature associated with the material that causes CPV dips. In fact, these offsets seem to be more regular than the circumstellar emission itself, given our need to slightly shift the reference phases in Figures 2 and 3 in order to provide plausible visual agreement with the data.

Summarizing, the low-resolution observations show $\delta\approx$1-3% broad-band flux dips corresponding to $\approx$5-20% variations in Hα EW. If the occulting cloud were gas-free, and made only of dust, this would not happen: dust does not selectively absorb light at 6563 Å. These observations are therefore consistent with the idea that the transiting material must include hydrogen.

3.3. *A near-infrared break in the extinction law*

CPV dips tend to appear deeper in the blue than in the red (M. N. Günther et al. 2022; C. Koen 2023), which C. Koen (2023) attributed to extinction by sub-micron dust. Since chromaticity provides a key constraint on the composition of the occulting material, we combined our own multi-color photometry with archival literature photometry, and measured the broadband dip depths using a single homogeneous procedure.

3.3.1. *Extinction law methodology*

We collected literature photometry from observations of CPVs showing at least one dip that was observed in at least two bandpasses simultaneously. Implicitly we also required the dips themselves to be clearly distinguishable (based on $\mathrm{d}f/\mathrm{d}t$) from spot-induced modulation, which is also chromatic. We excluded non-simultaneous literature datasets even when they carried novel information (e.g., the Spitzer 4.5 μm light curve from D. R. Ciardi et al. 2015) due to the time-variable nature of CPV dip depths. Further, we excluded *(i)* the TESS-band measurements for TIC 262400835, due to their low S/N and uncertain crowding correction; and *(ii)* the simultaneous SPECULOOS-South and TESS photometry of TIC 20178925 from M. N. Günther et al. (2022), because its ground-based and TESS dips show different durations, which is inconsistent with the fitting assumptions we describe below.

The results are in Table 4. All told, this data collection effort yielded 51 dip depth measurements spanning 0.44–2.16 μm over five stars and twenty distinct dip epochs. Half of these measurements are new from this work; the remainder are from TIC 435899024 (C. Koen 2023) and PTFO 8-8695 (M. Onitsuka et al. 2017; Y. Tanimoto et al. 2020).

We then fitted an extinction law to the dip depths by considering variants of a model in which

$$\delta \propto \lambda^{-\beta}, \tag{1}$$

where δ is the dip depth and β encodes how strongly the occultation deepens toward the blue. Positive β corresponds to deeper dips at shorter wavelengths, as expected for extinction by sub-micron dust; $\beta = 0$ is achromatic (gray), as expected for an optically thick occulter.

Working in logarithmic space, we defined $y_i = \log_{10}\delta_i$, yielding an uncertainty $\sigma_y \approx |\mathrm{d}y/\mathrm{d}\delta|\sigma_\delta = \sigma_\delta/(\delta\ln 10)$, for dip index i at an epoch $e(i)$. Here we use "$e(i)$" to refer to the set of all multi-wavelength measurements of one dip at a given epoch, and we use "$s(i)$" to refer to the set of all observed dips for any given star. We further found it convenient to define $\Lambda_i \equiv \log_{10}(\lambda_{\mathrm{eff},i}/\lambda_0)$, where λ_0 is an arbitrary reference wavelength, with a corresponding depth at that wavelength δ_0. For convenience, we chose λ_0=0.788 μm, the effective wavelength of the TESS bandpass. We calculated the effective wavelengths of the various bandpasses using the SVO Filter Profile Service (C. Rodrigo & E. Solano 2020). We then considered four model variants:

$$\mu_i = c_{e(i)} - \beta\Lambda_i \quad \text{(single power law)}, \tag{2}$$
$$\mu_i = c_{e(i)} - \beta_{s(i)}\Lambda_i \quad \text{(per-star power law)}, \tag{3}$$
$$\mu_i = c_{e(i)} - \beta_{e(i)}\Lambda_i \quad \text{(per-epoch power law)}, \tag{4}$$
$$\mu_i = c_{e(i)} - \beta_1 w_i + (\beta_1 - \beta_2)h_i \quad \text{(broken power law)}, \tag{5}$$

where $c_{e(i)} \equiv \log_{10}\delta_{0,e(i)}$ is a fitted reference depth defined at the reference wavelength λ_0. For observations that have TESS measurements, $c_{e(i)}$ will be near the observed TESS depth; for those without, $c_{e(i)}$ will be an extrapolation based on whichever bands were observed. Finally, in the broken power-law model, $w_i \equiv \log_{10}(\lambda_{\mathrm{eff},i}/\lambda_b)$ is the log-wavelength offset from a free break wavelength λ_b, and $h_i \equiv \kappa\ln(1+e^{w_i/\kappa})$ is a smoothing function that ensures a continuous gradient in the transition from β_1 blueward of the break to β_2 redward of it. In the broken power-law model, we take λ_b as the reference wavelength for the per-epoch amplitudes $c_{e(i)}$ rather than λ_0, and we set the smoothing scale to κ=0.01 dex, since our data do not constrain it. Finally, our priors on the fits were $\beta \sim \mathcal{N}(0,3)$, $c_{e(i)} \sim \mathcal{N}(\langle y_i\rangle, 1)$, and, for the broken power-law model, $\lambda_b/\mu\mathrm{m} \sim \mathcal{U}(0.7, 1.6)$. We assumed a Gaussian likelihood, $y_i \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu_i, \sigma_i)$, where we let $\sigma_i = (s_i^2 + \sigma_{\mathrm{int}}^2)^{1/2}$ optionally add an intrinsic scatter term to the per-dip uncertainties. We sampled using PyMC (O. Abril-Pla et al. 2023), and required $\hat{R} < 1.01$ with no divergences as an indicator of convergence.

Table 5. Extinction law fitting results ($\delta \propto \lambda^{-\beta}$), including goodness of fit and the mean $\pm$ std. dev. for β from the four models. The number of model free parameters k and degrees of freedom $\nu = N - k$ are given as no-$\sigma_{\rm int}$/with-$\sigma_{\rm int}$ pairs. Both χ^2_ν columns are evaluated against measurement error alone, s_i, not the value $\approx$1 obtained once the fitted $\sigma_{\rm int}$ is added in quadrature. ΔBIC is relative to Model 4 within each variant.

			χ^2_ν		ΔBIC		β	
Model	k	ν	no $\sigma_{\rm int}$	with $\sigma_{\rm int}$	no $\sigma_{\rm int}$	with $\sigma_{\rm int}$	no $\sigma_{\rm int}$	with $\sigma_{\rm int}$
Single	21/22	30/29	8.39	13.85	127.8	23.0	0.47 ± 0.02	0.46 ± 0.08
Broken [a]	23/24	28/27	7.25	12.31	76.6	16.3	—	—
β_1 (blueward)	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.68 ± 0.07	0.79 ± 0.16
β_2 (redward)	—	—	—	—	—	—	-0.10 ± 0.31	-0.09 ± 0.39
Per-star	25/26	26/25	5.43	10.58	32.9	7.7	—	—
TIC 262400835	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.51 ± 0.05	0.51 ± 0.18
LP 12-502	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.98 ± 0.07	0.97 ± 0.21
TIC 300651846	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.19 ± 0.04	-0.01 ± 0.14
TIC 435899024	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.55 ± 0.06	0.53 ± 0.32
PTFO 8-8695	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.59 ± 0.05	0.57 ± 0.10
Per-epoch	40/41	11/10	4.48	5.79	0.0 [b]	0.0 [b]	—	—
TIC 262400835, 2020 Dec 13	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.21 ± 0.10	0.28 ± 0.21
2020 Dec 15	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.60 ± 0.07	0.61 ± 0.19
2020 Dec 16	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.60 ± 0.09	0.61 ± 0.23
LP 12-502, 2023 Dec 08	—	—	—	—	—	—	1.32 ± 0.09	1.34 ± 0.21
2023 Dec 15	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.54 ± 0.11	0.65 ± 0.19
TIC 300651846, epoch 1	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.22 ± 0.04	0.22 ± 0.13
epoch 2	—	—	—	—	—	—	-0.54 ± 0.25	-0.54 ± 0.26
epoch 3	—	—	—	—	—	—	-0.01 ± 0.18	-0.01 ± 0.19
TIC 435899024, 2021 May 25–Jun 01	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.55 ± 0.06	0.53 ± 0.20
PTFO 8-8695, 2014 Jan 19	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.63 ± 0.12	0.63 ± 0.19
2014 Feb 23	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.87 ± 0.19	0.87 ± 0.22
2014 Dec 27	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.25 ± 0.14	0.25 ± 0.18
2015 Jan 10	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.08 ± 0.20	0.08 ± 0.23
2015 Jan 23	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.96 ± 0.50	0.94 ± 0.58
2015 Feb 10	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.85 ± 0.21	0.85 ± 0.26
2015 Feb 14	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.67 ± 0.10	0.67 ± 0.15
2015 Feb 23	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.26 ± 0.26	0.25 ± 0.29
2016 Feb 9	—	—	—	—	—	—	1.50 ± 0.25	1.50 ± 0.32
2016 Nov 25	—	—	—	—	—	—	-0.16 ± 0.34	-0.16 ± 0.43
2016 Dec 9	—	—	—	—	—	—	0.93 ± 0.34	0.93 ± 0.43

[a] Break wavelength $\lambda_b = 1.22 \pm 0.31\,\mu$m (no $\sigma_{\rm int}$), $1.18 \pm 0.27\,\mu$m (with $\sigma_{\rm int}$).

[b] All four models suffer pathologies connected to the need to fit the reference depth terms "$\delta_{0,i}$". However, this problem is most severe for the per-epoch model, since 13 of 20 epochs have two bands and are therefore fit exactly (zero residual χ^2 regardless of the true β). This model's minimization of ΔBIC is an artifact of the incidental-parameters problem, not evidence of real epoch-to-epoch variation. See Section 3.3.2.

3.3.2. *Extinction law results*

Figure 9 and Table 5 summarize the results. While Figure 9 shows the single power-law and broken-power law results in the $\delta/\delta_{0.788\,\mu{\rm m}}$–$\lambda_{\rm eff}$ plane, we emphasize that the fits are in the space of y_i vs. Λ_i. The normalization $\delta_{0.788\,\mu{\rm m}}$ is the model-derived reference depth at the TESS effective wavelength for each dip epoch in Equations 2–5. To provide a consistent normalization for visual comparison, we adopted the $\delta_{0.788\,\mu{\rm m},i}$ values from the "per-star" power law fits, which favors neither of the two displayed models.

All four models agree that the dip depths are chromatic. The model-comparison diagnostics also indicate that a single power-law extinction curve can be improved upon, either by introducing a population-wide flattening of the extinction toward the near-infrared, or by invoking epoch-to-epoch or star-to-star variability in the power-law index. The detailed interpretation is subject to three key underlying issues: whether the depth uncertainties s_i can be treated at face

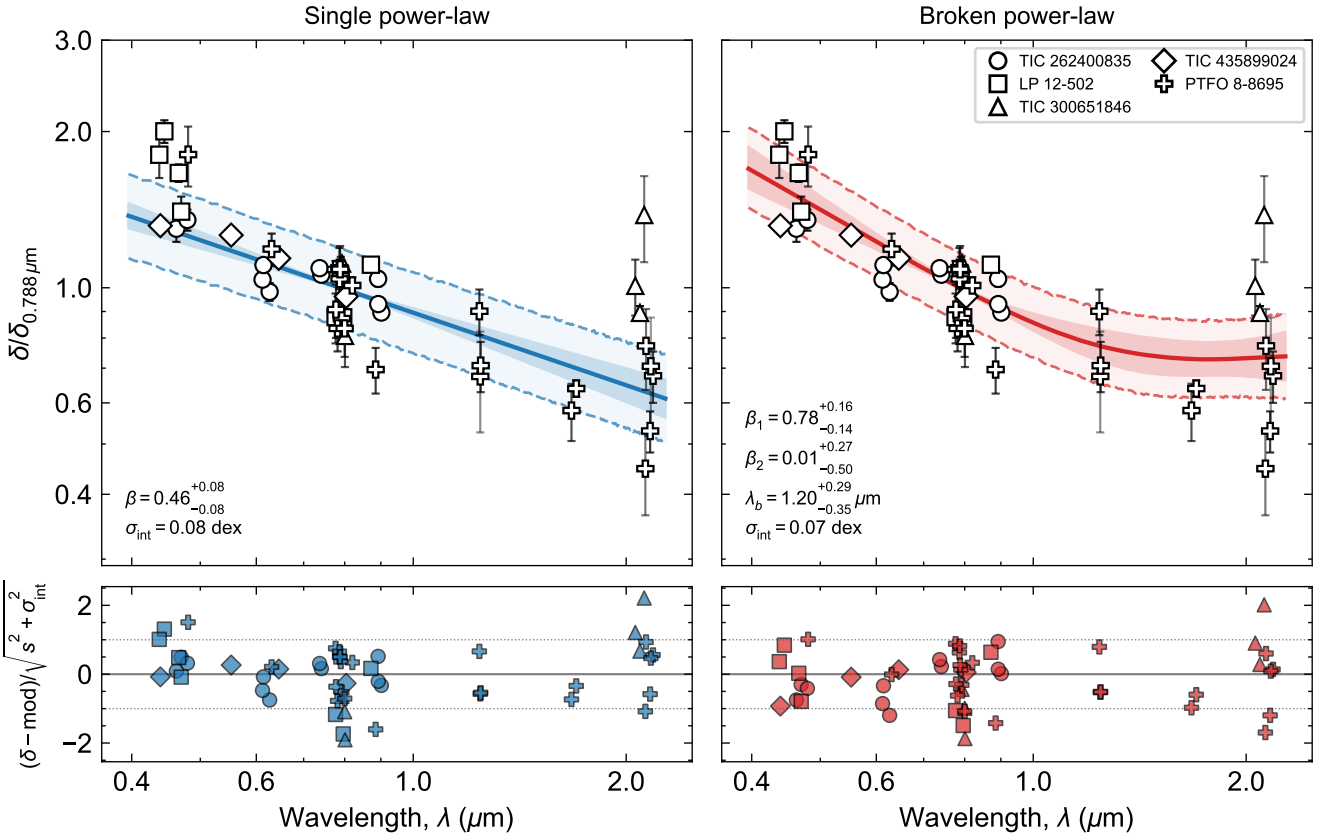


Figure 9. Chromaticities of complex periodic variable dips. Markers show the measured dip depth in each bandpass from Table 4, with small horizontal jitter added for visual clarity. The normalization factor $\delta_{0.788\,\mu m}$, the depth at TESS-band (λ=0.788 μm), is a model-derived quantity per combination of star and observing epoch (see Section 3.3). The solid line and inner band are the posterior-median and the 68% confidence interval of the mean $\delta(\lambda)$ relation; the outer band is the 68% predictive interval after additionally accounting for intrinsic variability (σ_{int}). Including σ_{int}, there is a positive preference (ΔBIC=6.7) in favor of the broken power-law. Excluding σ_{int}, there is a strong preference for the broken power-law (ΔBIC=51.2). *References*: TIC 262400835, LP 12-502, and TIC 300651846: this work. TIC 435899024: C. Koen (2023). PTFO 8-8695: L. Yu et al. (2015), M. Onitsuka et al. (2017), Y. Tanimoto et al. (2020).

value, how to weigh each model's effective parameter count, and the degree to which the data can select between the models.

If the dip depth uncertainties were unreliable, then we would want to incorporate an intrinsic scatter term σ_{int}, effectively down-weighting the most precise measurements and weakening our ability to make model-selection claims on a ΔBIC basis. We calibrated the reported depth uncertainties as described in Section 2.11, using the empirical out-of-dip scatter in each time-series dataset. The data and fitted model uncertainties (see Appendix B) suggest that this procedure is indeed yielding uncertainties that agree with the scatter in the data. As one example, our refit to the archival literature photometry from M. Onitsuka et al. (2017) yielded statistical uncertainties 10-17$\times$ larger than the published values, mirroring the observed scatter. Our dip depth uncertainties therefore seem plausible.

Nonetheless, the core drawback of treating our dip depth uncertainties at face value is that when we do this, the two simple models — a universal power-law, and a broken power-law extinction curve — both provide poor fits to the data (χ^2_ν=8.39 and 7.25, respectively). While inspection of χ^2_ν and ΔBIC in Table 5 would instead suggest that letting β vary on a per-epoch basis is preferred, that choice has serious drawbacks. In particular, the "β per-epoch" model is pathological for dips observed with only two simultaneous bandpasses, comprising over half the dataset: this model precludes χ^2 or BIC from accruing any residual information because it adds free parameters at the same rate as new data points. While we explored leave-one-out style analyses as a possible replacement strategy for counting *effective* free parameters, we ultimately found that with this dataset we were unable to produce a reliable ranking of this "per-epoch" model compared against the other models. To some degree, all four models suffer this "incidental parameters problem" (T. Lancaster 2000), in that every new observation epoch requires fitting and marginalizing over the depth at the reference wavelength; the problem is just most severe for the per-epoch model.

In brief, two divergent choices can improve on the single power law: one could introduce a population-wide break that

flattens the extinction toward the near-infrared, or one could invoke epoch-to-epoch or star-to-star variability. Making the (strong) assumption that the extinction law must be universal, the preferred model is a broken power-law with $\beta_1 = 0.79 \pm 0.16$ blueward of the break at $\lambda_b = 1.18 \pm 0.27$ μm, and $\beta_2 = -0.09 \pm 0.39$ redward of it. Intuitively, this model seems to provide the more plausible explanation for the narrowband FourStar 2.09 μm observations shown in Figure 6, which yielded dip depths $0.80 \pm 0.03\times$ the TESS depth, compared to a predicted ratio from the single-β fit of 0.64 ± 0.05 with $\sigma_{\rm int}$ (2.9σ), or 0.63 ± 0.01 without (5.9σ). With that said, we cannot formally exclude the possibility that TIC 300651846 is a low-β star with no extinction-law break.

4. DISCUSSION

4.1. *An opaque core and an optically thin halo of dusty plasma*

It is tempting to read Table 5 and Figure 9 as measurements of the dust opacity law, $\kappa(\lambda)$, whose shape is connected to the size distribution and composition of the dust grains. While $\delta(\lambda)$ and $\kappa(\lambda)$ are related, there is a nuance: the mapping is only direct when the occulting material is optically thin. Nothing about the data guarantees that we are in this regime. Consider an absorbing clump of material occulting a uniform stellar disk of area $A_\star$. The dip depth δ is

$$\delta(\lambda) = \frac{1}{A_\star} \int \left[1 - e^{-\kappa \Sigma}\right] dA, \tag{6}$$

where Σ is the surface density of the dust, κ is the opacity (and only wavelength-dependent term), and the integral is over the dust clump's area. Approximating $\kappa(\lambda) \propto \lambda^{-\beta}$ in the optical and near-infrared, one can show that the *observed* slope $\beta_{\rm obs}$ from $\delta(\lambda)$ in Figure 9 is related to the *underlying* dust opacity law's β through

$$\beta_{\rm obs} \equiv -\frac{d \ln \delta}{d \ln \lambda} = \beta \frac{d \ln \delta}{d \ln \kappa}. \tag{7}$$

The derivative on the right-hand side is a "dilution factor" which lies between 0 and 1 for any surface density distribution. The observed dip-depth $\beta_{\rm obs}$ of Table 5 and Section 3.3 therefore provides only a lower bound on the dust opacity's β, with the two related by Equation 7.

Figure 10 quantifies this damping for representative surface-density profiles and mean optical depths. Note that while the "uniform sphere" profile has $\Sigma(r) \propto (R^2 - r^2)^{1/2}$, this is not visible in the top panels due to the color stretch. The Gaussian has width w such that $\Sigma(r) \propto \exp(-r^2/(2w^2))$. The middle panel shows that for the smooth profiles, by a mean optical depth $\bar{\tau} \approx 1$ the observed slope falls to 40–60% of the intrinsic slope, and by $\bar{\tau} \approx 3$ to 20–30%. The lower panel gives example vertical slices from the middle, setting $\bar{\tau}$=3 for the smooth profiles and exploring the impact of dilution on a "steep" β=2 intrinsic grain opacity. All models flatten the extinction curve. However, even after accounting for this dilution, comparison with Figure 9 shows that the

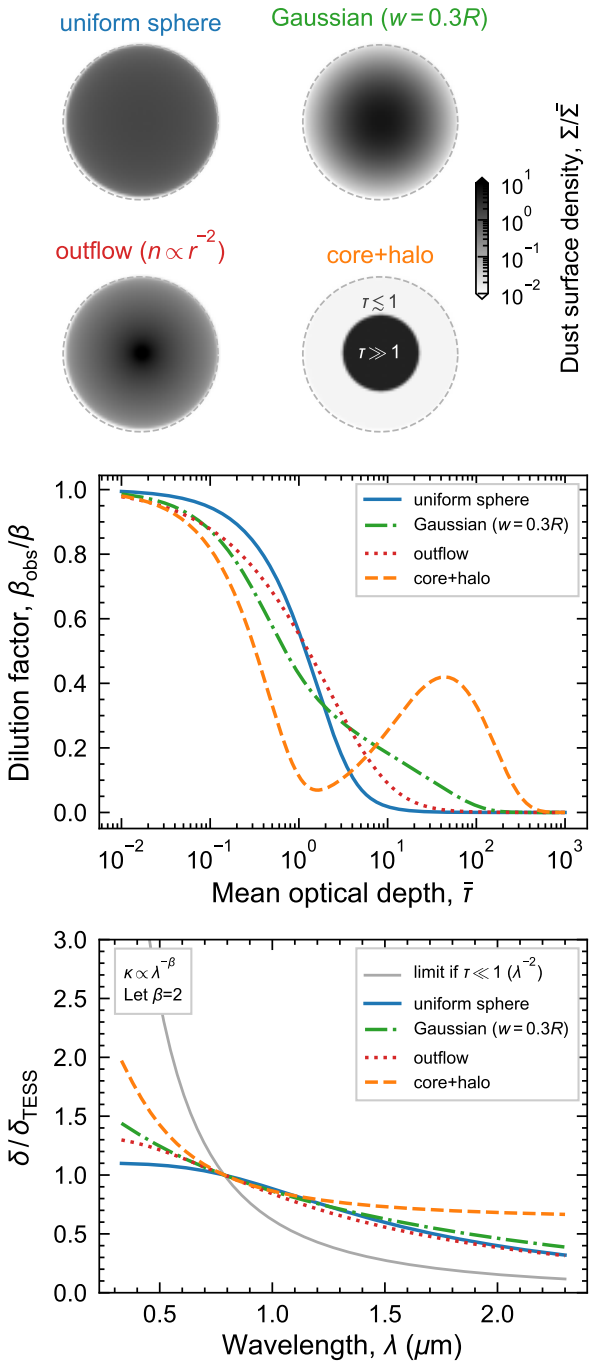


Figure 10. Partial opacity dilutes chromaticity. *Top*: surface density maps for four example clump profiles. The "uniform sphere" has constant number density; the "core+halo" (Equation 8) has $A_{\rm h}/A_{\rm c}$=3. *Middle*: the factor by which an intrinsic dust opacity $\kappa \propto \lambda^{-\beta}$ is diluted into an observed dip chromaticity, $\delta \propto \lambda^{-\beta_{\rm obs}}$ (Equation 7). The mean optical depth, $\bar{\tau}$, is averaged over the clump's projected disk. At fixed R and κ, profiles with equal $\bar{\tau}$ contain equal dust mass. *Bottom*: example spectra for β=2; the smooth profiles set $\bar{\tau}_{\rm TESS}$=3, and the core+halo profile sets $\tau_{\rm h}$=0.1 at 1.2 μm. Only the bimodal core+halo profile matches Figure 9.

smooth profiles provide a poor fit to the data: their blue dips are not deep enough, and their K-band dips are too shallow.

If dust provides the opacity, the simplest physical interpretation of a broken power-law in $\delta(\lambda)$ is to therefore invoke a *bimodal* surface density distribution: an opaque core of projected area A_c ($\tau \gg 1$ out through K band) surrounded by an optically thin halo of area A_h and depth $\tau_h(\lambda)$. Such a distribution yields

$$\delta(\lambda) \approx \frac{A_c}{A_\star} + \frac{A_h}{A_\star}\left[1 - e^{-\tau_h(\lambda)}\right], \tag{8}$$

such that the infrared depths sit on the core's gray floor while the optical depths are dominated by the halo's chromatic term, with the break falling near where the two terms are comparable. The "core+halo" curve in the lower panel of Figure 10 shows a toy example with A_h/A_c=3 and $\tau_h(1.2\,\mu\mathrm{m})$=0.1: the same β=2 opacity law that the smooth profiles flatten into a gray curve instead yields a broken power law resembling the data. A brute-force exploration of the parameter space indicates an allowed parameter range of $1 \lesssim A_h/A_c \lesssim 30$, $10^{-4} \lesssim \tau_h \lesssim 0.3$ at 1.2 μm, and $1 \lesssim \beta \lesssim 4$, where the upper bound on β is the Rayleigh-scattering limit. This range of β excludes the possibility of a population dominated by mm to cm-sized solids, but is otherwise consistent with a wide range of dust compositions and size distributions.

4.2. *Where do the dust and plasma come from?*

Where does the occulting material responsible for CPV dips come from? Figure 11 sketches three possible scenarios. Starspots are present in every scenario since CPVs are young, magnetically active, and show smooth rotational modulation over which the dip signals are superposed. While dark facular networks could also be present (A. I. Shapiro et al. 2026), they are relevant only in that they could influence this smooth variability.

In scenario *(i)*, the plasma clumps condense out from the star without any dust being present (e.g. S. Daley-Yates & M. M. Jardine 2024), and a very specific starspot geometry is also required. In this scenario, the chromaticity of the dips needs to somehow be provided by the plasma, the spots, or a combination thereof. However the plasma cannot do it alone: neither H^- opacity nor hydrogen bound-free opacity provide the correct functional forms. Instead, the most likely opacity source would be scattering from the free electrons (Thomson scattering); this would need to be combined with the "transit light source effect" (B. V. Rackham et al. 2018) in which unocculted spots outside the transit chord provided the apparent chromaticity. Exploring such models however shows that the requisite spot-covering fractions f are in the range of 70–90% of the stellar area. CPVs often require $R/R_\star \gtrsim 0.1$. The geometric probability of having clear transit chords for the entire chromatic ensemble of observed CPV dip is sufficiently low to be ruled out. Separate arguments against this scenario include the lack of response in the light curves to changes in circumstellar emission (Section 3.1), and the **Facundo(?): the evidence from TSPEC spectra for starspot covering fractions $f \lesssim$XX% in LP 12-502**.

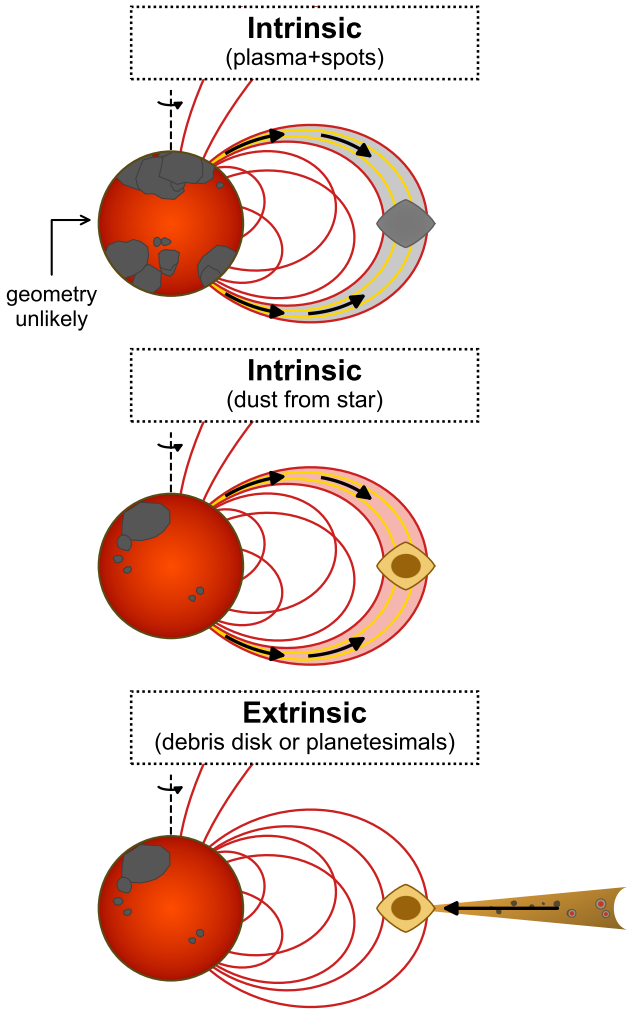


Figure 11. Origin scenarios for the opaque occulting material. *Top*: corotating plasma clumps plus high starspot filling factor and no dust. *Center*: Dust condensing from magnetically confined stellar plasma. *Bottom*: Dust captured from an extrinsic reservoir (debris disk or undetected planetesimals). The dust-free scenario is disfavored; the lower two remain possible, and differ in where the dust originates. At least some starspots are present in all scenarios. The stars must have "centrifugal" magnetospheres with magnetospheric radii R_m exceeding their corotation radii R_c; the clumps remain long-lived only between the two extremes.

While we disfavor Scenario *(i)*, the data remain compatible with both Scenarios *(ii)* and *(iii)*. In either dust scenario, the dust becomes collisionally charged (H. Sanderson et al. 2023), enabling it to remain magnetically confined (S. Daley-Yates et al. 2026). The two scenarios may differ in their expected extent of mixing between the gas and dust, as well as in the composition of the grains themselves. Either dust origin channel would be yielding new information: in Scenario *(ii)* we would learn that young M dwarfs condense out dust, similar perhaps to how this happens in the atmospheres of AGB stars (S. Höfner & H. Olofsson 2018). In

Scenario *(iii)* we would gain a new way of identifying and studying the detritus of planet formation.

4.3. *Continued relevance of PTFO 8-8695*

The saga of PTFO 8-8695 (CVSO 30), whose data appear in Figure 9, provides unique connections to the current CPV literature. To recap: J. C. van Eyken et al. (2012) identified a hot Jupiter candidate in Orion; J. W. Barnes et al. (2013) and S. Kamiaka et al. (2015) subsequently argued that its orbit was nodally precessing, and C. M. Johns-Krull et al. (2016) found that the source showed sinusoidal-in-time Hα emission at circumstellar velocities. Photometric follow-up found the planet candidate's orbital period to stay fixed, but that the ephemeris jumped around in orbital phase and split into multiple dips per cycle (D. R. Ciardi et al. 2015; L. Yu et al. 2015; S. Raetz et al. 2016; M. Onitsuka et al. 2017; Y. Tanimoto et al. 2020). L. G. Bouma et al. (2020) used TESS and Gaia to argue that the system shows multiple indicators for being an intermediate-separation (multiple AU) binary, one component of which shows an ordinary rotation signal, and the other component being a complex periodic variable. While this interpretation may not be uniformly accepted (T. A. Grosson & C. M. Johns-Krull 2021), further photometric follow-up by R. Bischoff et al. (2022) has been broadly consistent.

The characterization of PTFO 8-8695 provided photometric and spectroscopic details that have been remarkably prescient for understanding CPVs. Spectroscopically, C. M. Johns-Krull et al. (2016) showed evidence for Balmer variability similar to that seen for TIC 141146667 and TIC 300651846, and consistent with the idea of bound circumstellar plasma being present. Photometrically, Y. Tanimoto et al. (2020) monitored the source for five years in optical and infrared bands, and observed a break in the chromaticity of this system's dip depths going out to *K*-band similar to that reported in this work. One of their proposed resolutions was the scenario of an opaque dust core with an optically thin dust halo—and this is exactly the scenario that we favor from Section 3.3.2. The Spitzer 4.5 μm light curve observed by D. R. Ciardi et al. (2015) showing a 0.5% deep dip in 2012 remains a unique dataset, and it remains the only information we have about the chromaticities of any CPV dips redward of *K*-band.

4.4. *The chromaticity differs from analog magnetic rotators*

Massive magnetic B stars are the only class of star known to exhibit similar light curves to CPVs. The prototype, σ Ori E, has a long history (e.g. J. D. Landstreet & E. F. Borra 1978; R. H. D. Townsend et al. 2005; M. E. Oksala et al. 2015), but the summary is that it hosts a centrifugally supported magnetosphere in which a long-lived "pinched" plasma torus (R. H. D. Townsend 2008) produces photometric eclipses and sinusoidal-in-time spectroscopic emission. L. G. Bouma et al. (2024) argued that the additional step to produce "complex" light curves comes from magnetic topology, on the basis that the few σ Ori E analogs showing complex light curves also show (rare) evidence from Zeeman Doppler imaging for non-dipolar magnetic fields. The analogy extends to the radio: σ Ori E shows rotationally modulated gyrosynchrotron emission from its corotating magnetosphere (P. Leto et al. 2012), and polarized, variable radio emission has now been reported for two CPVs, DG CVn (S. Kaur et al. 2025) and TIC 146539195 (S. Kaur et al. 2024; S. Curiel et al. 2026).

While physical analogies can be drawn, the chromaticities of the σ Ori E analog eclipses are different from what is seen for CPVs. J. E. Hesser et al. (1977) and M. Oksala & R. H. D. Townsend (2007) provided photometry that showed near-gray chromaticity in *vby*, with a slight depth decrease in *v* relative to *y*, and a major depth increase in *u*. This behavior mirrors the hydrogen bound-free opacity curve as a function of wavelength (D. F. Gray 2008): the Balmer break at 3646 Å captures the *u* band, while *vby* would have a slight decrease before the break. This is consistent with the opacity in the σ Ori E analogs coming purely from trapped hydrogen. While *u*-band photometry of CPVs does not exist, their behavior in the *griz* optical bands is inconsistent with the predictions of the bound-free opacity.

5. CONCLUSIONS

CPVs show a combination of smooth, rotationally-induced modulation, along with sharp dips induced by the transits of magnetically bound circumstellar material. The occulting material must be circumstellar because of how quickly it causes the broadband flux to change, and magnetically bound because of its synchronicity with the stellar rotation period and its sensitivity to flaring (J. Stauffer et al. 2017; L. G. Bouma et al. 2024). The composition of the circumstellar material could, a priori, be gas, dust, or a combination thereof. In this work we find that while circumstellar gas is conspicuously present, dust seems to provide the opacity source responsible for the dips.

Gas is conspicuously present *(i)* because of sinusoidal-in-time Balmer emission out of transit, and *(ii)* because of Balmer line extinction during transit. Plasma clump emissivity out of transit was first seen in CPVs for TIC 141146667 ($n_{\rm H}\approx1\times10^{11}$ cm^{-3}; L. G. Bouma & M. M. Jardine 2025). Observing TIC 300651846 and LP 12-502 at comparable sensitivity gave a detection of bound emitting circumstellar plasma for TIC 300651846 ($n_{\rm H}\approx3$–8×10^{11} cm^{-3}; Section 3.1), and upper limits for LP 12-502 ($n_{\rm H}\lesssim5\times10^{10}$ cm^{-3}; Appendix A.1). The quoted range for TIC 300651846 comes from the six-fold variation in Hα clump luminosity seen night-to-night, implying a number density variation of 2.5×. This large spectroscopic change was accompanied by no discernable changes in simultaneous TESS data. The lack of correlation between light curve morphology and circumstellar plasma number density suggests that gas is not responsible for the sharp dips, leaving dust as the only viable culprit.

The gas and dust appear spatially associated: both the high-resolution (Figures 2 and 3) and low-resolution (Figure 4) time-series spectra show Hα transits occurring simultaneously or near-simultaneously with broadband flux transits. We did observe departures from strict simultaneity

through repeatable transit timing offsets for two stars: for TIC 300651846 the deepest Hα minimum preceded the deepest broadband flux local minimum by $\approx$25 minutes on all five nights from January 2025; for LP 12-502 the offset was $\approx$50 minutes late over both nights in November 2023.

Chromaticities from broadband photometry currently provide the best information about the dust composition. We compiled our new observations with the literature and fitted four variants of a $\delta \propto \lambda^{-\beta}$ extinction curve: a single power-law, a broken double power-law, a power-law that let β vary per-star, and a power-law that let β vary per epoch. The results, shown in Table 5 and Figure 9, show that the two simpler models (single and broken power-law) both yield poor fits ($\chi^2_\nu \gg 1$). This suggests either that there is star-to-star or epoch-to-epoch variability in the extinction law (produced for instance by an inhomogeneous and evolving dust population), or that there is an unknown source of intrinsic scatter that requires inflating the observed dip depth uncertainties. Our analysis also highlighted the challenge of formal BIC-based model comparison for these data: the epoch-to-epoch depth variability of CPVs implies that we must marginalize over a transit depth at a reference wavelength for each observing epoch, which negates the statistical value of two-band epochs that lack TESS data.

Our results therefore leave an open degeneracy: one can improve on the single power law extinction curve by either introducing a broken power-law, or by invoking epoch-to-epoch or star-to-star variability in the power-law index. While these ideas are not mutually exclusive, they cannot be distinguished with the current data because the near-infrared data for TIC 300651846 and PTFO 8-8695 come with only a single optical anchor point each. Nonetheless, a broken power-law seems to provide the simplest explanation for the depth of CPV dips in the infrared (see Figure 6, and D. R. Ciardi et al. 2015). Our fits for such a model yielded $\beta_1 = 0.79 \pm 0.16$ blueward of the break at $\lambda_b = 1.18 \pm 0.27\,\mu$m, and $\beta_2 = -0.09 \pm 0.39$ redward of it.

The break, rather than the slopes, carries most of the physical information (Sections 4.1 and 4.2). The *observed* optical chromaticity β_1 provides a lower bound on the *intrinsic* spectral index of the dust opacity: for $\kappa \propto \lambda^{-\beta}$ we infer $1 < \beta < 4$. This excludes a dust population dominated by mm to cm-sized solids, but is otherwise consistent with a wide range of dust compositions and size distributions. The break itself can be produced by a bimodal dust surface density distribution: an opaque core surrounded by an optically thin halo. We find that such a model can reproduce the data for halo to core area ratios $1 \lesssim A_\mathrm{h}/A_\mathrm{c} \lesssim 30$ and halo optical depths $10^{-4} \lesssim \tau_\mathrm{h} \lesssim 0.3$ at 1.2 μm.

While all approximations are wrong, some are useful. The core+halo picture is useful in that it reproduces the observed extinction curve with a minimum of ingredients; it is surely also wrong in its details. Spectral features of the occulting dust and gas, particularly in the ultraviolet and infrared where data are currently lacking, offer one area for future work.

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Contributions: LGB led the inception, design, execution, and interpretation of the project. Data were acquired and reduced by JHL, KI, NN, and AK (MuSCAT1); EP, FM (MuSCAT2); JGM, PT, DC (Tierras); AB (KeplerCam); FPP (TSPEC); and LGB (MIKE, MagE, FourStar, HIRES, DBSP, TSPEC). Observations by JSS (FourStar) and ASC (HIRES), and reduction assistance by HI and AWH (HIRES) enabled the work. AM helped plan and interpret the FourStar observations. Finally, FPP, LAH, AJW, JJS, MMJ, JAV, and DRC contributed to the interpretation of the results, and all authors reviewed the manuscript.

Facilities: Magellan:Baade, Magellan:Clay, Keck:I, Hale, OAO:1.88m, Sanchez, FLWO:Tierras, FLWO:1.2m, Gaia, TESS, 2MASS, SDSS.

Software: astroariadne (J. I. Vines & J. S. Jenkins 2022), astropy (Astropy Collaboration et al. 2013, 2018, 2022), carpy (D. D. Kelson et al. 2000; D. Kelson 2003), DBSP_DRP (M. S. Mandigo-Stoba et al. 2022b), dustmaps (G. Green 2018), matplotlib (J. D. Hunter et al. 2007), numpy (S. Van Der Walt et al. 2011), PyMC (O. Abril-Pla et al. 2023), PypeIt (M. S. Mandigo-Stoba et al. 2022a), scipy (P. Virtanen et al. 2020).

APPENDIX

A. SPECTROSCOPY OF CPVS OUTSIDE THE NARROW FLUX DIPS

In the main text we focus on photometric and spectroscopic signatures of the circumstellar material present around CPVs. However, due to the long-term unpredictability in CPV light curve morphology, some nights yielded coverage of only spot-induced or flare-induced broadband flux variability without providing any evidence—spectroscopic or photometric—for bound circumstellar material. We describe the results of those observations below.

A.1. *Keck/HIRES*

Figure 12 summarizes TESS and HIRES data for LP 12-502 on the nights of 23 November 2023, 3 December 2024, and 10 December 2024. The static spectra exhibit Balmer series emission up to n=15→2, strong chromospheric emission in the Ca II H&K lines, and the expected forest of molecular absorption lines for a non-accreting ("weak-lined") pre-main sequence M4.5Ve dwarf.

The HIRES spectra show flare-induced variability over all three nights. The most direct indicator for this variability is in chromospheric emission lines; excess emission appears during the variable epochs while the redder orders, including the order-normalized continuum, appear stable. This spectral variability is temporally coincident with elevated TESS flux levels (Figure 12), and is symmetric in the blue and red wings of the Balmer lines in the time-dynamic spectra, consistent with electric field-induced pressure broadening (A. F. Kowalski et al. 2017). This structure is mirrored across numerous chromospheric lines, including the entire Balmer series, the Ca II H&K lines, Ca I 4226, He I 4026, He I 4471, the Na doublet, and the Mg triplet. The flaring epochs also coincide with the excitation of at least a dozen Fe I lines spanning 3820 Å–4050 Å(A. Kramida et al. 2024). These lines are not present in the quiescent spectra; they appear in emission with $\Delta\lambda\approx$0.2 Å over the few-hour duration for which the other flare diagnostics are also present. This is consistent with established phenomenology for M dwarf flares (B. Fuhrmeister et al. 2008).

While the HIRES spectra and photometry of LP 12-502 presented abundant evidence for flare-induced variability, no variability could be clearly associated with any bound circumstellar hydrogen. Nonetheless, the same calculation as in Section 3.1, enables a conversion of this non-detection of Hα emission to an upper limit on the number density of bound circumstellar plasma. For LP 12-502, $L_\star$=0.011±0.001 $L_\odot$, $R_\star$=0.37±0.01 (L. G. Bouma et al. 2024), and we measure a mean stellar Hα EW and scatter of 0.22 ± 0.02 Å. The implied stellar Hα line luminosity is $\approx 3.0\times10^{26}$ erg s^{-1}, two orders of magnitude lower than TIC 300651846. We derive an upper limit on the equivalent width of any excess Hα by injecting synthetic emission into the spectra shown in Figure 12. This process indicated that we would have been sensitive to circumstellar Hα emission with EW $\gtrsim$ 10 mÅ. As a result, we can rule out plasma clumps with number density $n_{\rm H} \gtrsim 5\times10^{10}$ cm^{-3}, or assuming $r\approx0.1\,R_\star$, any clumps with $M_{\rm gas}\gtrsim6\times10^{15}$ g. This limit on the clump hydrogen number density is an order of magnitude lower than the densities observed for TIC 141146667 ($\approx1\times10^{11}$ cm^{-3}; L. G. Bouma & M. M. Jardine 2025) and TIC 300651846 (3–8$\times10^{11}$ cm^{-3}; Section 3.1).

A.2. *Hale/DBSP*

Figure 13 shows three near-adjacent nights observing LP 12-502 with Hale/DBSP. Figure 14 gives a complete visualization of the TESS flux and DBSP Hα EW behavior over the five adjacent nights in November 2024, folded on the 18.56 hour period. While LP 12-502 exhibited extreme variability from 2019–2023, showing four to eight sharp flux dips per cycle, it displayed only one or two sharp flux dips from May to December 2024 (TESS Sectors 78–86). A movie showing the star's TESS light curve from 2019–2025 is **available online**. In our November 2024 DBSP run, flare-induced variability played a significant role

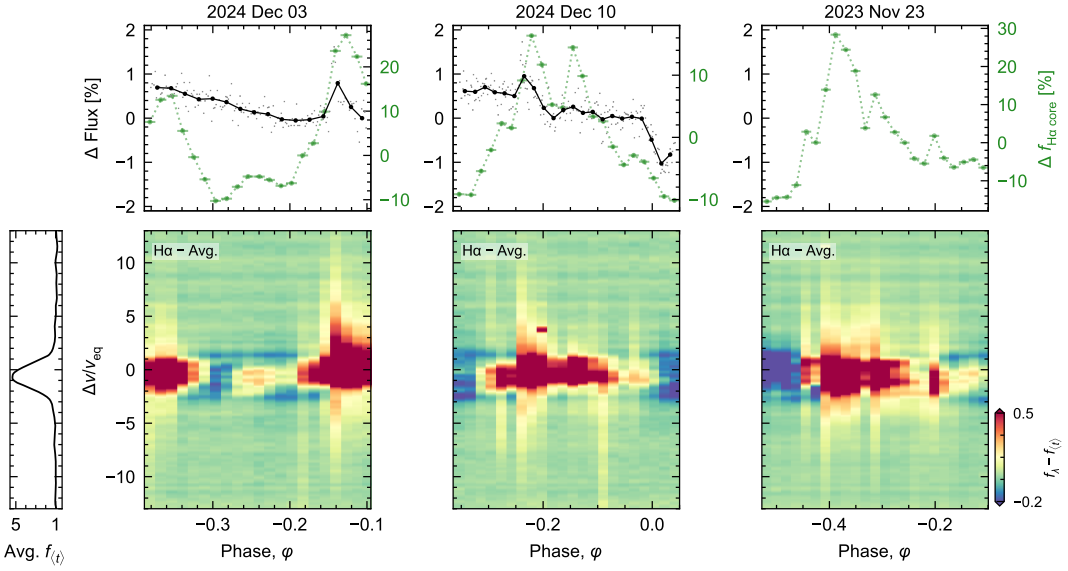


Figure 12. Flare-induced variability of LP 12-502 viewed through Keck/HIRES and TESS. The lower left panel shows the time-average Hα profile on 3 December 2024. The successive columns show the time-dynamic mean-subtracted Hα profiles on the bottom. On top, simultaneous TESS flux measurements are in black, with the median-normalized Hα line flux at $|v/v_{\rm eq}| < 1$ in green. The lack of (bound) circumstellar emission yields an upper limit on the number density of any plasma clumps, discussed in the text.

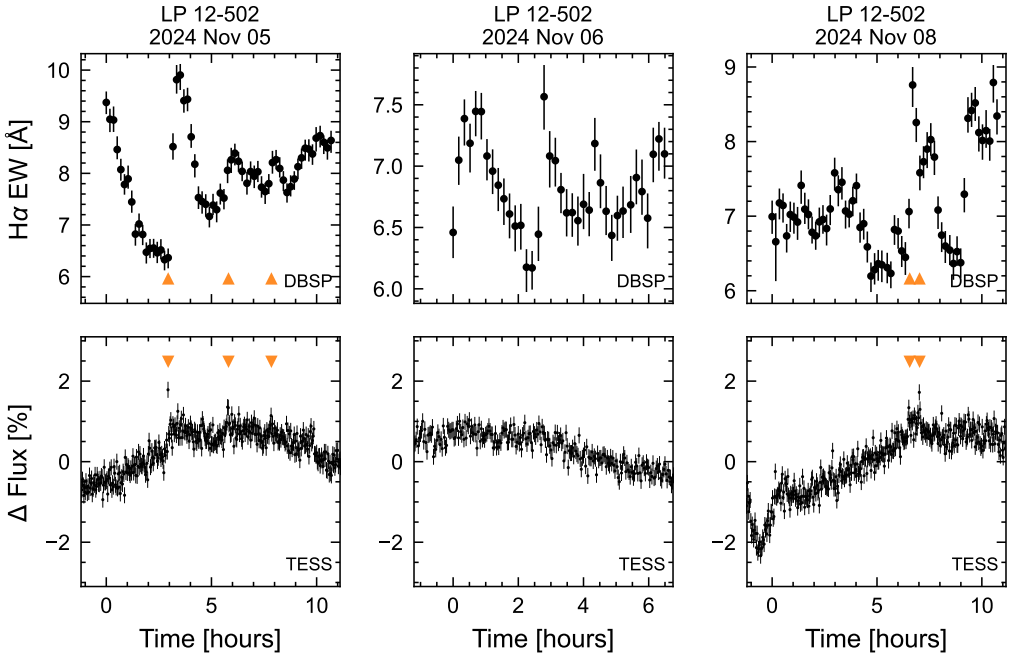


Figure 13. Hale/DBSP Hα equivalent widths (EWs) vs. simultaneous TESS photometry during "non-complex" windows. Panels are as in Figure 4, but for the three nights with only flare- and spot-induced variability. On Nov 5, flare-induced local maxima occur at t=3.5, 6, and 8 hours; on Nov 6 a similar maximum occurs at t=2.6 hours; and on Nov 8, at $t\approx$6.5 hours. The Nov 8 DBSP observations began just after the end of a sharp "complex" flux dip.

in modulating the Hα equivalent width measurements, and only two of the five nights (discussed in the main text) overlapped with the complex flux dips that define the CPV class.

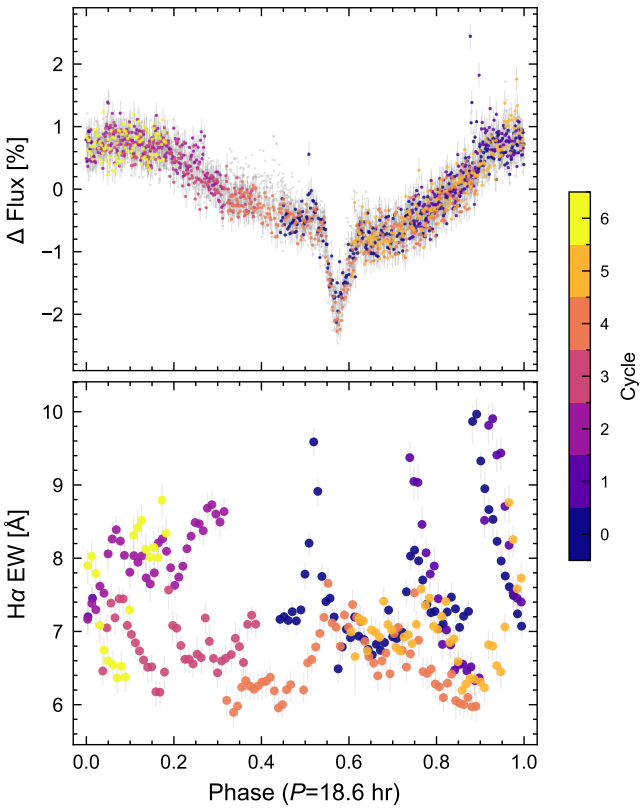


Figure 14. LP 12-502 Hale/DBSP Hα equivalent widths (EWs) vs. simultaneous TESS photometry from 4 November 2024 to 8 November 2024. Points are colored by their orbital cycle number relative to the first 18.56 hour period. Simultaneous TESS measurements using the main colormap; TESS data in the 4 November to 8 November baseline that were not covered *simultaneously* by DBSP due to the day-night cycle are shown in gray.

B. TIME-SERIES PHOTOMETRY FITTING DIAGNOSTICS

Figures 15 and 16 show the results from our photometry fitting routine, which forms the basis for the chromaticity analysis in Section 3.3.

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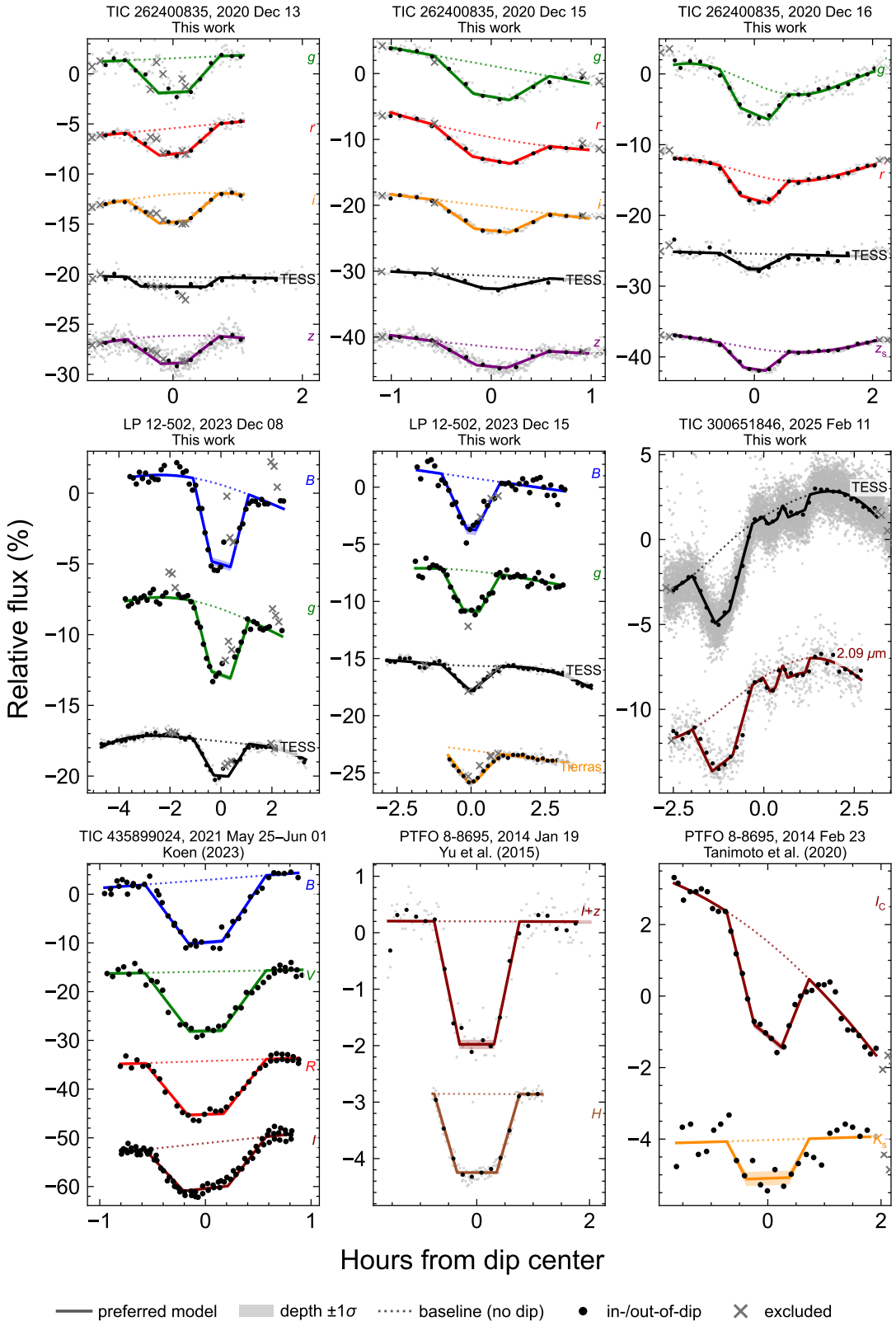


Figure 15. Trapezoidal fits to multi-band photometry of CPVs (part 1/2). Data from TIC 262400835, LP 12-502, and TIC 300651846 and new to this work. We digitally transcribed the measurements from TIC 435899024 (C. Koen 2023) and PTFO 8-8695 (L. Yu et al. 2015; Y. Tanimoto et al. 2020). Dip depth uncertainties (± 1-σ) are shown in the underplotted contours.

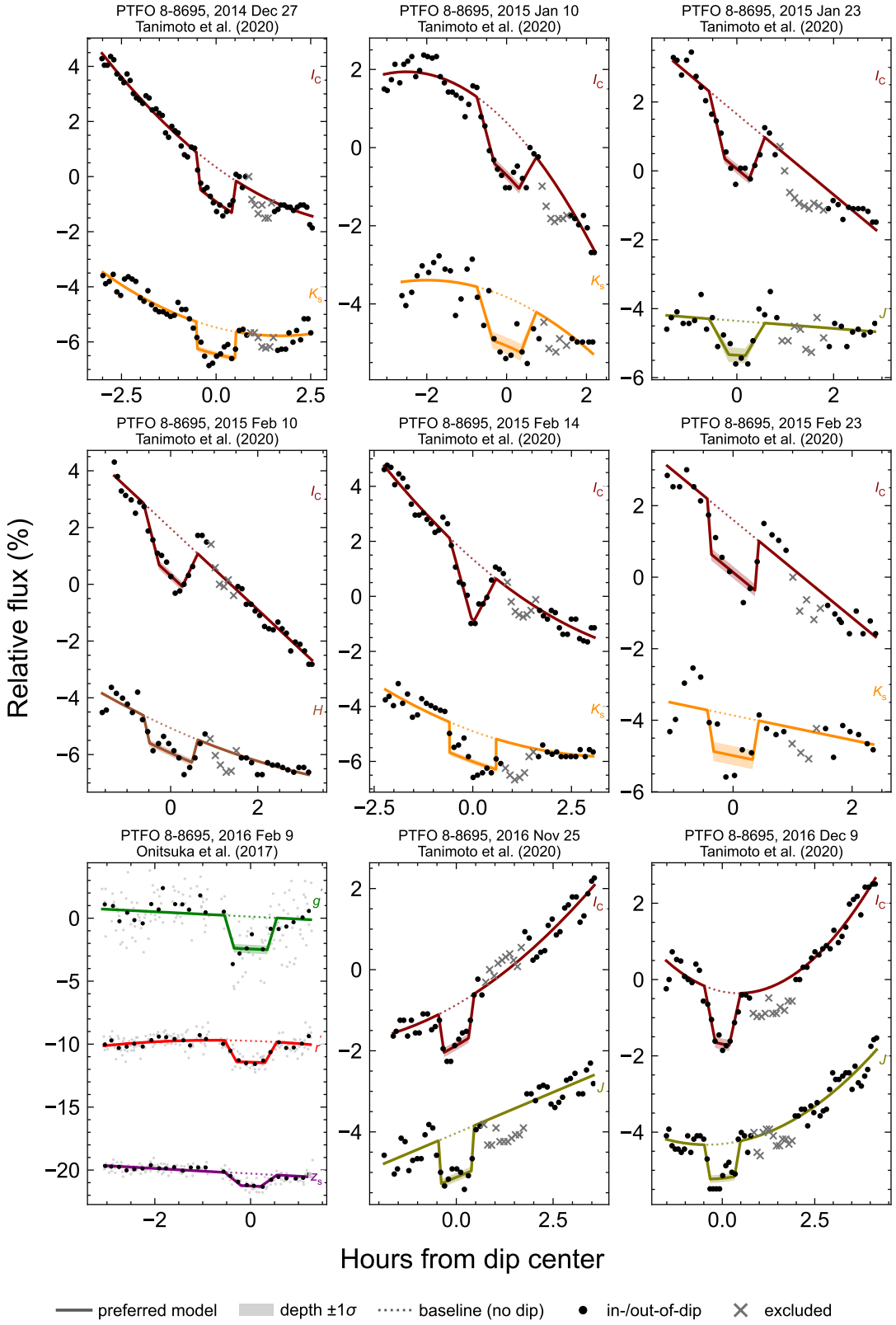


Figure 16. Trapezoidal fits to multi-band photometry of CPVs (part 2/2). We digitally transcribed these PTFO 8-8695 measurements from M. Onitsuka et al. (2017) and Y. Tanimoto et al. (2020). The underplotted contours show our fitted ± 1-σ dip depth uncertainties.

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